

MINISTRY OF EDUCATION AND TRAINING
QUY NHON UNIVERSITY

HO THAI BAO QUYNH

**HEDGING DEVICES IN THE FILM “THE SOCIAL
NETWORK” (2010): SIMILARITIES AND
DIFFERENCES FROM A GENDER PERSPECTIVE**

Field: English Linguistics
Code: 822.02.01

Supervisor: Truong Van Dinh, PhD

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**BỘ GIÁO DỤC VÀ ĐÀO TẠO
TRƯỜNG ĐẠI HỌC QUY NHƠN**

HỒ THÁI BẢO QUỲNH

**CÁC PHƯƠNG TIỆN RÀO ĐÓN TRONG PHIM
“THE SOCIAL NETWORK” (2010): NHỮNG ĐIỂM
TƯƠNG ĐỒNG VÀ KHÁC BIỆT TỪ GÓC NHÌN
GIỚI TÍNH**

Ngành: Ngôn ngữ Anh

Mã số: 822.02.01

Người hướng dẫn: TS. Trương Văn Định

STATEMENT OF AUTHORSHIP

I hereby certify that this project “Hedging Devices in the Film ‘The Social Network’ (2010): Similarities and Differences from a Gender Perspective” is my own work. I have not used any person’s work other than those identified as references and listed in the bibliography. I confirm that this study has not been submitted elsewhere in any other forms for any purposes.

Gia Lai, 2025

Ho Thai Bao Quynh

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Ho Thai Bao Quynh

ABSTRACT

This study investigates the similarities and differences in the usage of hedging devices by male and female characters within the competitive communicative environment of the film *'The Social Network'* (2010). Employing a mixed-methods approach, the research draws on Yu's (2009) framework for the quantitative classification of hedge types and a synthesized model based on the works of Lakoff (1975), Brown and Levinson (1987), Holmes (1995), and Hyland (1998) for the qualitative analysis of their pragmatic functions. The analysis reveals a significant disparity in incidence, with male characters hedging nearly five times more often than female characters, establishing it as a predominantly male linguistic strategy in the film. While both genders show a propensity for modal hedges, the most profound difference lies in their pragmatic application. The findings indicate that male characters employ an assertive and instrumental toolkit, using hedges for persuading, achieving strategic vagueness, and asserting dominance. In contrast, female characters utilize a responsive and accommodative toolkit, with hedges primarily used for mitigating face-threatening acts, managing conflict, and creating space for response in a discourse dominated by others. Ultimately, the study challenges the traditional view of hedging as a sign of uncertainty or a "feminine" trait, arguing instead that in this competitive context, hedging functions as a strategic and powerful rhetorical tool whose use is tied more to a character's narrative role and power position than to their gender itself.

Keywords: hedging devices, gender, pragmatic functions, power dynamic, politeness strategies

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ABBREVIATIONS

F Female FTA

Face-Threatening Act

M Male

CONVENTIONS

Bold	used for highlights key terms and specific hedges in examples
<i>“italic”/italic</i>	used for names of sitcoms/books and direct quotations acting as examples
“Double Quotes”	Used for direct quotes from academic sources and all dialogue examples.

CHAPTER 1.

INTRODUCTION

1.1 Rationale

The evolution of human civilization has profoundly shaped communication, with the interplay of gender and language emerging as a critical area of linguistic inquiry. Within this domain, hedging devices-linguistic strategies used to soften assertions, express uncertainty, and maintain politeness-play a pivotal role in managing interpersonal dynamics. As society becomes increasingly aware of the nuances in cross-gender communication, understanding the distinct ways men and women employ these devices is essential for fostering effective dialogue and navigating complex social interactions. The strategic use of hedges, therefore, is not merely a stylistic choice but a fundamental component of pragmatic competence that reflects and shapes social relationships.

While the phenomenon of hedging has attracted considerable scholarly attention, existing research, both internationally and in Vietnam, has predominantly focused on its use in formal, structured contexts such as academic writing and scientific discourse. Consequently, a significant gap remains in the literature: there is a notable lack of investigation into how hedging devices function in dynamic, context-rich spoken dialogue that simulates real-life interactions. The similarities and differences in how men and women strategically deploy hedges in spontaneous conversation, where interpersonal relationships are actively negotiated, remain an underexplored area.

The present study aims to address this gap by analyzing the use of hedging devices from a gender perspective in the film *'The Social Network'* (2010). By examining the pragmatic functions of hedges in scripted, yet naturalistic, conversations, this research offers several key contributions. Firstly, it will expand the theoretical understanding of hedging beyond written texts to its application in spoken, relational discourse. Secondly, it will provide empirical insights into how gendered linguistic patterns are represented in contemporary media, reflecting modern communication norms. Ultimately, this analysis of how male and female characters navigate power dynamics and interpersonal conflict will illuminate the strategic, rather than passive, role of hedging in conversation. These reasons motivate the present study, titled *"Hedging Devices in the film 'The Social Network' (2010): Similarities and Differences from a Gender Perspective"*.

1.2 Aim and Objectives of the Study

1.2.1 Aim of the Study

The study aims at investigating the use of hedging devices in the film *'The Social Network'* (2010), with a focus on identifying and comparing the similarities and differences in how male and female characters use these devices in conversations, in order to shed light on gendered communication patterns and the pragmatic functions of hedging devices in communication.

1.2.2 Objectives of the Study

The study attempts to accomplish the following objectives:

- (1) To identify the types of hedging devices used by male and female characters in *'The Social Network'* (2010);
- (2) To point out the gender similarities and differences in using hedging devices in the film *'The Social Network'* (2010);
- (3) To examine the pragmatic function of hedging devices employed by male and female characters in the film *'The Social Network'* (2010);
- (4) To compare the similarities and differences in the pragmatic functions of hedging devices used by male and female characters in the conversations in the film *'The Social Network'* (2010).

1.3 Research Questions

To achieve the aim and objectives, the researcher collected and analyzed data to answer the following questions:

1. What types of hedging devices are used by male and female characters in the film *'The Social Network'* (2010)?
2. What are the gender similarities and differences in the use of hedging devices by male and female characters in the film *'The Social Network'* (2010)?
3. What pragmatic functions do hedging devices used by male and female characters perform in the conversations in the film *'The Social Network'* (2010)?
4. What are the similarities and differences in the pragmatic functions of hedging devices used by male and female characters in the conversations in the film *'The Social Network'* (2010)?

1.4 Scope of the Study

The present study is limited to the identification and analysis of hedging devices, which are classified according to Yu's (2009) model, and whose pragmatic functions are identified based on a synthesized theoretical framework drawing from the works of Lakoff (1975), Brown and Levinson (1987), Holmes (1995), and Hyland (1998).

The data for the study consists of all the dialogues of male and female characters in the film *'The Social Network'* (2010).

The study focuses exclusively on linguistic devices and does not extend to paralinguistic factors. While certain paralinguistic elements may arguably function as hedging devices, their identification is highly complex and remains unresolved in scholarly debate. Accordingly, paralinguistic factors are excluded from consideration in this study.

1.5 Significance of the Study

Theoretically, the study contributes to the literature on the analysis of hedging in general, and gendered differences in the use of hedging in spoken discourse in particular.

Practically, the study can raise awareness for learners of English regarding the different ways men and women use hedging devices in communication. This understanding can, in turn, help them improve their cross-gender communication skills.

1.6 Organization of the Study

The study consists of five main chapters.

Chapter 1, *Introduction*, introduces the study, which includes the rationale, justification, the scope of the study, the research questions, the hypothesis, and the organization of the study.

Chapter 2, *Literature Review*, presents the overview of hedges and the film ‘*The Social Network*’ by David Fincher.

Chapter 3, *Research Methods and Procedures*, mentions the Aim, objectives, research methods, research organization, data collection, data analysis, and corpus description.

**Chapter 4, *Findings and Discussion*,
demonstrates the findings and discusses how
men and females use hedge devices in the film
'*The Social Network*' (2010)**

Chapter 5, *Conclusion*, synthesizes the research by summarizing the key findings, discussing their implications, acknowledging the study's limitations, and proposing directions for future research.

CHAPTER 2. LITERATURE REVIEW

This chapter establishes the theoretical foundation for the present study. It begins by reviewing the core concepts in sociolinguistics and pragmatics relevant to this research, particularly the relationship between language and gender. The chapter will then define the study's central phenomenon, hedging devices, and present the analytical frameworks adopted. This includes Yu's (2009) framework for the quantitative classification of hedge types and a synthesized model for the qualitative analysis of pragmatic functions, which draws upon the seminal works of Lakoff (1975), Brown and Levinson (1987), Holmes (1995), and Hyland (1998).

2.1 An Overview of Hedges

The concept of 'hedge' is a cornerstone of pragmatic and sociolinguistic research, yet it remains a multifaceted and debated term. This section aims to build a solid theoretical foundation by systematically reviewing the literature on hedging. It will first survey the evolution of its definition, then present key frameworks for its classification, and finally synthesize its various pragmatic functions in discourse. This overview established the necessary groundwork for the analysis presented in the following chapters.

2.1.1 Definition of Hedge

The concept of 'hedge' is notoriously difficult to define precisely. Over the decades, linguists across various fields such as philosophy, semantics, and pragmatics have proposed numerous definitions, each reflecting a different theoretical lens.

Lakoff (1972, 1973) was among the first to conceptualize hedges, defined hedges as *“words whose meaning implicitly involves fuzziness words whose job is to make things fuzzier or less fuzzy”* (p. 471). He viewed hedges as linguistic devices that enable speakers to express partial commitment to a proposition's truth, allowing for gradience and approximation in meaning. This marked a significant departure from traditional notions of linguistic precision, highlighting instead the inherently variable nature of language in social contexts.

From the point of view of semantics and logic, Zadeh (1972) argued that hedges vary in their dependency on context. They are operators acting on the fuzzy set representing the meaning of their operands.

Lakoff (1975) extended his analysis by associating hedging with gendered speech. He proposed that women tend to use more hedge such as *I think, maybe, or I'm not sure-* due to social norms encouraging politeness and deference. This perspective positioned hedging not merely as a stylistic choice but as a reflection of power imbalances in communication.

Based on Lakoff's work, Prince et al. (1982) marked a pivotal development in the conceptualization of hedging. While Lakoff primarily defined hedges in relation to

semantic "*fuzziness*," Prince et al. shifted the focus towards the speaker's pragmatic intent. Their analysis of physician-physician discourse revealed that hedging is not just about making statements less precise, but more significantly, it is a tool for speakers to signal their degree of commitment to the truth of a proposition. This contribution was crucial because it moved the definition of hedging from a purely semantic concept to a pragmatic and interactional one, paving the way for future studies to analyze hedging as a strategic choice reflecting the speaker's stance and social context.

Building upon and simultaneously challenging the initial perspectives of Lakoff, the work of Holmes (1995) offered a multifunctional and more balanced view of the concept of hedging. Whereas Lakoff tended to interpret women's frequent use of hedging as an expression of powerlessness (the deficit model), Holmes provided a crucial and influential distinction. She argued that hedging performs at least two primary functions: one is to express genuine epistemic uncertainty, and the other is to act as a positive politeness strategy for building relationships and maintaining social harmony.

This contribution was highly significant because it reshaped the scholarly debate. Rather than viewing hedging as a mere sign of hesitation, Holmes demonstrated that it is a sophisticated and intentional linguistic tool. Her research, based on empirical data, affirmed that the function of a hedging device is not fixed but is entirely dependent on the interactional context - a finding that has guided much subsequent sociolinguistic research.

In addition, the pragmatic aspects of hedges are also quite prominent in some studies. Brown and Levinson (1987, p. 145) stated that hedges might be regarded as "*a particle, word or phrase that modifies the degree of membership of a predicate or a noun phrase in a set, it says of that membership that it is partial or true only in certain respects or that it is more true and complete than perhaps might be expected*". The definition shows that the hedging phenomenon is based on the politeness aspects of communication.

In addition, hedges are considered straighteners as well as weakeners. Hedging pragmatic phenomena is also contributed by Salager-Meyer (1994), who revealed that hedging is related to vagueness and fuzziness. It is "*the product of a mental attitude which looks for prototypical linguistic forms*". (1994, p. 176)

Vietnamese scholars have also contributed significantly to the discussion. For instance, Nguyen (2002) conceptualized hedging from a primarily interactional and preventative standpoint. He defined hedging as an expressive tool whose main purpose is to act as a safeguard against potential "*unexpected misunderstandings and reactions*" from the listener. This perspective frames hedging not merely as an indicator of the speaker's uncertainty, but as a proactive, strategic choice aimed at managing the interpersonal consequences of an utterance. By using a hedge, the speaker anticipates how their words might be received and preemptively softens the message to maintain conversational harmony and protect both their own and the hearer's face. In this view, the social function of hedging - to ensure a smooth and conflict-free interaction-is paramount.

Adopting a more proposition-focused perspective, Nguyen (2003) identified hedging as a linguistic "*strategy used to hedge the propositional content*" of an

utterance. This definition centers on the relationship between the speaker and the information they are conveying. According to this view, the primary function of a hedge is to modulate the speaker's commitment to the truth-value of their statement. It allows the speaker to present information cautiously, signaling that the proposition may not be absolute, universally applicable, or based on complete knowledge. Rather than focusing on the listener's reaction, Nguyen's approach emphasizes the speaker's epistemic stance, viewing hedging as a critical tool for expressing nuanced claims and avoiding the risk of being proven definitively wrong.

Furthermore, Yu (2009) stated that the concept of hedges is based on pragmatic and social language. He referred to relationships between interlocutors and social relationships in a broader context, with a focus on interpersonal and social relationships through three aspects:

(1) Hedge as a linguistic means (prosodic, lexical, syntactic, discoursal, or strategic) that contributes to good interpersonal relationships or good interactional behavior in communication.

(2) Hedge performing more social functions such as saving the speaker's or the hearer's face, protecting the writer's or his/her institution's reputation, projecting the speaker's or the writer's personality, strengthening solidarity with the addressee, or gaining ratification from the reader.

(3) Very rarely, hedge as a text or discourse organizer or as a pointer for interpreting the text or discourse while simultaneously performing one or more of the functions above.

Hedging has been studied in different aspects, depending on researchers' viewpoints. This evolution of definitions, from the semantic 'fuzziness' of Lakoff to the complex socio-pragmatic functions proposed by Yu, illustrates that a hedge cannot be understood through a single lens. Rather, it is a multifunctional linguistic tool whose meaning is deeply embedded in context, speaker intent, and social interaction.

2.1.2 Classification of Hedges

The classification of hedges has been approached from various theoretical perspectives, each offering insights into the form, function, and communicative role of hedging in discourse. Among the most influential contributions are those of Grice (1975), Brown and Levinson (1987), Hyland (1998), Salager-Meyer (1994), and Yu (2009), whose frameworks have shaped contemporary understanding of this linguistic phenomenon.

Grice's (1975) Cooperative Principle forms the foundation for many subsequent models of pragmatic analysis. According to Grice, effective communication is governed by four conversational maxims-Quantity, Quality, Relation, and Manner-which speakers are expected to observe. In this framework, Hedges are viewed as strategies to signal potential non-fulfillment of a maxim, thereby allowing the speaker to maintain politeness or mitigate the strength of a claim. For instance, expressions such as *"I'm not sure if this is relevant, but..."* or *"As far as I know..."* indicate that the speaker may not fully meet the maxim of relation or quality,

respectively. Thus, hedges operate as metapragmatic cues that negotiate an utterance's degree of informativeness, truthfulness, relevance, and clarity.

One of the most foundational frameworks for classifying hedges was proposed by Prince et al. (1982). Their work introduced a crucial functional distinction, dividing hedging devices into two main categories based on how they interact with the proposition.

The first category, approximators, consists of linguistic items that directly modify the propositional content, making a statement intentionally vague or less precise. These devices, which include common expressions such as *sort of*, *kind of*, and *approximately*, affect the "fuzziness" of the information being conveyed.

The second category, shields, operates on a different level. Instead of altering the proposition itself, shields reflect the speaker's epistemic stance, signaling their degree of commitment to the truth of the statement. Examples of shields include phrases like *I believe*, *it seems*, and *I guess*. This classification was a significant contribution as it provided a clear model to distinguish between hedges that modulate the information itself (approximators) and those that comment on the speaker's relationship to that information (shields).

While Prince et al. focused on the speaker's epistemic stance, Brown and Levinson (1987) approached hedging from a more interactional perspective, incorporating it into their influential Politeness Theory. They formally defined a hedge as "*a particle, word or phrase that modifies the degree of membership of a predicate or a noun phrase in a set; it says of that membership that it is partial or true only in certain respects*" (p. 145). In their view, this function of modifying a proposition's certainty is a vital tool in managing face-threatening acts (FTAs). Hedges, therefore, are part of a broader repertoire of negative politeness strategies used to reduce the imposition on the hearer and demonstrate the speaker's respect for the interlocutor's autonomy. For example, qualifiers like "*I guess*," "*sort of*," or "*maybe*" are used to soften assertions and signal that the speaker is not imposing an absolute truth, thereby protecting the hearer's negative face. Their framework allows hedges to be classified based on their type of politeness work—whether in softening directives, mitigating disagreements, or downplaying assertions.

Salager-Meyer (1994) further developed a functional typology of hedging in scientific writing. She classified hedges into five categories: shields (e.g., *it seems that*, *to our knowledge*), approximators of degree, quantity, frequency, and time (e.g., *about*, *approximately*), expressions of probability (e.g., *probably*, *likely*), introductory phrases (e.g., *we believe that*, *it is thought that*), and question forms (e.g., *can it be that...*). Salager-Meyer emphasized the role of hedges in managing epistemic uncertainty, avoiding overgeneralization, and adhering to academic norms of cautious interpretation. Her work provided a more systematic linguistic inventory for identifying hedges in scientific and medical texts.

In the context of academic discourse, Hyland (1998) proposed a discipline-specific framework for understanding hedging, particularly in scientific writing. He defined hedges as linguistic devices that enable writers to project caution, flexibility, and awareness of audience perspectives. Hyland categorized hedges into various grammatical forms—modal verbs (*may*, *might*), epistemic verbs (*suggest*, *appear*), and adverbs (*perhaps*, *possibly*)—and emphasized their function in

positioning the writer within the academic community. Rather than viewing hedging as a sign of uncertainty, Hyland argued that it reflects a strategic rhetorical move to acknowledge alternative interpretations, maintain scholarly modesty, and anticipate possible objections from readers.

From a socio-pragmatic and interactional perspective, Yu (2009) proposed a three-level classification of hedging based on its linguistic form, social function, and discourse role. First, hedges are recognized as lexical, syntactic, prosodic, or discursial features that shape interpersonal interaction. Second, they serve relational functions such as maintaining solidarity, expressing politeness, or protecting the speaker's and hearer's social face. Third, Yu argued that hedges can act as discourse organizers, guiding interpretation or marking shifts in conversational direction. His model is beneficial for understanding hedges in spoken dialogue, where they function not only as expressions of doubt or politeness but also as strategic tools for navigating social relationships and communicative goals.

Among the various theoretical classifications presented, this study will adopt an integrated approach to identify and analyze hedging devices, primarily drawing from Grice's (1975) Cooperative Principle and Yu's (2009) socio-pragmatic and interactional framework.

Grice's theory provides the foundational pragmatic lens to understand *why* speakers employ hedges—often as a strategy to signal potential non-fulfillment of a conversational maxim while maintaining cooperation. Complementing this, Yu's multi-layered model offers a systematic methodology to classify the specific linguistic *forms* of hedges (lexical, syntactic, etc.) and analyze their interactional *functions* within the context of spoken dialogue.

The integration of these two perspectives allows for a comprehensive analysis, examining both the underlying pragmatic motivations and the observable socio-discursial strategies of hedging as employed by the characters in this study.

To further illustrate the classification of hedging expressions in relation to the four maxims of Grice (1975) and their face-saving functions as proposed by Brown and Levinson (1987), Table 2.1 summarizes common hedging types, examples, and their communicative purposes:

Table 2.1

Types of Hedges According to the Four Maxims

Types of Hedges Examples

Quality Hedges	I think, I believe, I assume, as far as I know, I'm confident that
Quantity Hedges	Roughly, more or less, approximately, to some extent
	This may not be relevant, if I may mention, I don't know
Relation Hedges	
	whether this matters
	If you see what I mean, I'm not sure if this makes sense, to put
Manner Hedges	
	it more simply

2.1.3 Hedging Functions

The conceptualization of hedging functions has evolved significantly over several decades, moving from a limited view of uncertainty to a more complex understanding of their strategic role in communication. A chronological overview of foundational studies clearly illustrates this progression.

The groundwork for the study of hedging functions was laid by Robin Lakoff in her classic work, *Language and Woman's Place* (1975). Lakoff was the first to systematically link hedging to women's speech, politeness, and tentativeness. According to her model, women's greater use of hedges reflected their subordinate social position and served as a strategy to avoid confrontation and soften utterances.

Based on Lakoff's work, Prince et al. (1982) provided a deeper cognitive analysis. They identified that hedges primarily function as devices for marking uncertainty or fuzziness in the meaning of a proposition. Their work classified hedges into "*approximators*" (which blur content) and "*shields*" (which reflect the speaker's stance), emphasizing hedging's role in modulating a speaker's commitment to the truth.

From a socio-pragmatic viewpoint, Brown and Levinson (1987) integrated hedging into their influential Politeness Theory. They did not focus on hedging as a standalone concept but viewed it as a key linguistic resource for performing negative politeness strategies. According to their framework, hedges function to mitigate Face-Threatening Acts (FTAs), thereby showing respect for the hearer's autonomy and minimizing imposition.

By 1990, Holmes offered a more multifunctional and balanced perspective. Holmes clearly distinguished two main functions of hedging: one was to express genuine uncertainty, and the other was to act as politeness strategies to maintain social harmony and relationships. She argued that women's greater use of hedges was not a "deficit" but rather a manifestation of a relational orientation in

communication.

Shifting to academic discourse, Salager-Meyer (1994) provided a detailed functional taxonomy. She identified hedging functions in medical texts to include shields, approximators, expressions of probability, and cautious framing of claims. Overall, her work showed that the core function of hedging in scientific settings is to manage epistemic uncertainty and adhere to the norms of the academic community.

Continuing in this vein, Hyland (1998) reframed hedging not as a sign of weakness, but as a strategic rhetorical move. Rather than just uncertainty, Hyland provided a clear taxonomy, proposing that hedges are a means of showing tentativeness, politeness, and strategic vagueness. He argued that hedging is an essential tool for writers to build relationships with readers and position themselves within their academic community.

In the following decade, researchers focused more on interactional and social functions. Yu (2009), proposed a multi-layered model comprising three main functional types: (1) a linguistic function (adjusting the tone and force of a message), (2) a social-interpersonal function (face-saving, maintaining harmony), and (3) a discourse-organizational function (managing turns, signaling transitions).

Finally, Fraser (2010) contributed to a broader categorization of pragmatic functions by making a crucial conceptual distinction. He argued that the primary function of hedging is to signal the speaker's stance toward the proposition (degree of certainty or commitment), whereas the function of politeness is to signal the speaker's stance toward the hearer (deference, respect). This distinction helps clarify that hedging and politeness are different concepts, although they frequently overlap.

From the diverse perspectives of the foundational studies presented, a list of the main functions of hedging in communication can be synthesized. For the purpose of analysis in the following chapters, this study will not adopt a single framework but will instead employ a synthesized model built upon the core contributions of several researchers.

Specifically, this analytical framework draws from Lakoff's (1975) initial connection between hedging and politeness; Brown and Levinson's (1987) theory of face-threatening acts; Holmes's (1995) distinction between relational and epistemic functions in gendered speech; and Hyland's (1998) view of hedging as a strategic rhetorical tool. Synthesizing these perspectives provides the basis for the comprehensive summary of functions that will be utilized in the present research, as presented in Table 2.2:

Table 2.2

Functions of Hedging Devices in Conversation

Function of Hedge	Description	Example
Expressing Uncertainty	Shows the speaker is not fully committed to the statement.	<i>"It might rain later."/ "I guess she's already left."</i>
	Reduces the force of requests,	<i>"Could you perhaps</i>
Politeness/Softening	suggestions, or criticisms. <i>explain that again?"</i> Softens disagreements, refusals,	
Mitigating Face-	<i>"I'm not sure that's</i>	
	or criticism to avoid sounding	
	Threatening Acts <i>entirely correct..."</i>	
	rude.	<i>"It seems that this</i>
Tentativeness/Open-	Leaves room for negotiation or	
		<i>approach could work</i>
mindedness	other viewpoints.	<i>better."</i>
	Builds rapport, invites	<i>"We kind of expected that,</i>
Solidarity/Inclusiveness	agreement, or shares	<i>didn't we?"</i>
	responsibility.	
	Avoids precision, useful when	<i>"He arrived around five</i>
Strategic Vagueness	details are unknown or	<i>or so."</i>
	unnecessary.	
	Makes suggestions or advice	

"Perhaps you should try

Persuasion Strategy sound softer and more

restarting the system."

acceptable.

Shows caution in presenting

Hedging information as fact, *"As far as I know, she*

Knowledge/Evidentiality acknowledges limits of *hasn't confirmed yet."*

knowledge.

Helps avoid direct *"Well, it could be*

Diplomatic Avoidance confrontation or taking a firm *interpreted in different*

stance. ways."

"I think this is the best

Creating Space for Gives the listener opportunity to

option, what do you

Response agree, disagree, or contribute.

think?"

The synthesized framework presented in Table 2.2, which draws upon these foundational sources, will serve as the primary analytical tool for identifying and interpreting the functions of hedging devices in the present study.

2.2 Importance of Hedges in Conversation

Conversation is one of the most fundamental and natural forms of human communication. It is characterized by spontaneity, interactivity, and mutual responsiveness. Unlike written discourse, the conversation is often informal, unplanned, and co-constructed by participants in real time. According to Yule (1996), conversation involves turn-taking, speaker negotiation, and shared assumptions, which help maintain coherence and relevance throughout the interaction.

Grice's (1975) Cooperative Principle provides a foundational framework for understanding how conversation works. This principle suggests that participants aim to cooperate by following four conversational maxims: quantity, quality, relation, and manner. While these maxims outline how conversation should ideally function, speakers often flout or strategically manipulate them to achieve specific communicative goals. Hedging is a strategy used when speakers want to soften their message, express uncertainty, or avoid face-threatening acts.

Furthermore, conversation is not only a site for exchanging information but also for performing social functions. It reflects power dynamics, social roles, cultural expectations, and personal attitudes. Because of its interactive nature, speakers constantly adjust their language based on the context, the listener, and the desired social outcome. In this context, hedging plays a crucial role in helping speakers manage both the content and the interpersonal aspects of their utterances.

Hedges are important in conversation for several reasons. First and foremost, they help speakers express tentativeness or uncertainty about a proposition. This is particularly useful when the speaker lacks complete information or wishes to avoid making absolute claims. Phrases like *I think*, *maybe*, *as far as I know*, or *it seems* allow the speaker to convey opinions cautiously, leaving space for negotiation and alternative viewpoints.

Secondly, hedges function as tools for mitigating face-threatening acts (FTAs). According to Brown and Levinson (1987), FTAs are speech acts that inherently risk damaging the listener's positive or negative face. Hedges help reduce this threat by making requests, suggestions, disagreements, or criticisms sound less direct. For example, saying *I'm not sure if this is right, but...* softens the impact of a potential correction or contradiction. As Myers (1998, p. 23) noted, "*the effect of hedging device is face-saving*." This supports the view that hedges operate within Brown and Levinson's politeness theory, where "*face*" refers to an individual's public self-image. Hedges protect the listener's negative face-their desire not to be imposed upon-and the speaker's positive face-their wish to be approved of and respected.

Hedges are, therefore, functional in conversation as they permit a delicate and sensitive way for speakers to handle social interactions. A good discussion typically involves more than simply presenting one's opinions-it requires balancing self-expression with respect for others' viewpoints and social positions. Through hedging, speakers can soften their words and reduce the chance of appearing overly assertive, imposing, or offensive. This tendency to balance politeness and assertion is especially valuable in informal settings, where overt authority may be socially inappropriate.

Moreover, hedges are essential when conversational contributions potentially violate Grice's (1975) Cooperative Principle. As Fraser (2010) clarified, the primary role of a hedge is to signal the speaker's level of commitment to the proposition being conveyed. In contexts of uncertainty, a direct, unhedged assertion carries significant risk, as it may be perceived as inaccurate or overly assertive. By employing a hedge, a speaker can temper their statement, explicitly marking their recognition of potential limitations in their own knowledge or the absolute validity of their judgment. This strategic signalling of a non-absolute stance serves to reduce the risk of being contradicted and invites a more flexible, negotiated interpretation of meaning within the conversation.

In addition to protecting face and managing uncertainty, hedges give speakers confidence to participate in discourse, even when their information or opinions may not be definitive. Expressions such as *I feel like* or *it seems to me* allow individuals to contribute without appearing overconfident or overly subjective. This can foster more open, respectful, and inclusive communication, where all participants feel their views are valued. Such hedging promotes cooperative discussions in which the

negotiation of meaning is prioritized over competition or confrontation.

Furthermore, hedging enhances the collaborative and dynamic nature of spoken language. Because conversation is often spontaneous and unplanned, speakers may revise their thoughts, introduce alternative perspectives, or adjust their expressions mid-utterance. Hedges provide the flexibility to do so without disrupting the interaction. In this sense, they help manage discourse flow and interpersonal alignment.

Finally, the use of hedges reflects broader cultural values and communication styles. In many Asian contexts, including Vietnamese culture, indirectness, humility, and harmony are emphasized in social interactions. As Nguyen (2002) pointed out, hedges are frequently employed to soften requests or suggestions, aligning with cultural norms of politeness and social hierarchy.

In summary, hedging devices contribute significantly to conversational efficiency and relational dynamics. They allow speakers to handle uncertainty, protect their faces, adapt to social expectations, and co-construct meaning with others. Far from mere indicators of hesitation or weakness, hedges are strategic tools supporting effective, respectful, and nuanced communication, reinforcing conversation as a socially embedded and interactional process.

2.3 Hedges and Politeness Strategies

Although hedging and politeness strategies often appear closely intertwined in communication, it is essential to distinguish between them to avoid conceptual conflation. While both serve interpersonal and interactional functions, hedging refers specifically to linguistic forms that convey the speaker's tentativeness, uncertainty, or reduced commitment to a proposition, whereas politeness strategies, as outlined by Brown and Levinson (1987), encompass a broader range of pragmatic tactics employed to mitigate face-threatening acts (FTAs) and maintain social harmony.

According to Brown and Levinson (1987, p. 145), hedges such as *perhaps*, *I think*, or *it seems* can function as key politeness markers. In their framework, the use of these devices to soften statements, avoid confrontation, or show deference is a linguistic realization of negative politeness, a strategy which aims to respect the hearer's desire not to be imposed upon. For instance, a sentence like *I'm not sure this is correct, but...* uses a hedge to signal humility, thereby reducing the risk of face loss for both the speaker and the listener. This direct link between hedging and politeness is further reinforced by Myers (1989), who noted that "*the effect of a hedging device is face-saving*" (p. 23). Therefore, in such cases, hedging is not merely a sign of uncertainty but a sophisticated interactional tool aligned with established principles of politeness theory.

However, it is important to note that not all hedges are politeness strategies, and none involve hedging. Some hedges reflect epistemic modality, indicating degrees of knowledge or belief rather than social intent. For example, *It might rain later* communicates the speaker's uncertainty about weather conditions but does not necessarily aim to mitigate interpersonal threats. Conversely, politeness strategies may include linguistic features that are non-hedging, such as address terms (*sir*, *my dear friend*), inclusive pronouns (*we*, *let's*), or indirect requests (*Could you*

possibly...), all of which serve social functions without involving epistemic softening.

Fraser (2010, p. 232) further differentiated between the two by emphasizing that hedging is primarily concerned with the speaker's stance toward the proposition-how certain or committed they are-whereas politeness strategies concern the speaker's stance toward the listener-how much they wish to accommodate, defer, or show respect. In this view, hedging can operate independently of politeness, especially in contexts such as academic writing or scientific discourse, where the goal is to present ideas cautiously rather than to maintain interpersonal rapport.

In light of the scholarly discussion, the key takeaway is not that a definitive, universally agreed-upon boundary exists between hedging and politeness, but rather that making an *analytical distinction* between them is methodologically crucial for this study. This approach is particularly vital when analyzing the layered intentions within cinematic dialogue. It provides the necessary framework to move beyond a simple identification of politeness and to more accurately interpret whether a character's hedge is used to appear less assertive, to manipulate, to maintain power dynamics, or to express genuine uncertainty. Therefore, treating them as functionally distinct-while acknowledging their frequent co-occurrence-offers the precision required to investigate the complex relationship between pragmatic strategies and gendered patterns of interaction.

2.4 An Overview of Gender and Politeness Strategies

Language use is deeply embedded in social and cultural systems, and gender is one of the most influential factors shaping linguistic behavior. In the study of pragmatics and sociolinguistics, considerable attention has been paid to the role gender plays in the use of politeness strategies. Various scholars have explored how men and women differ - or are perceived to differ - in their approach to politeness, indirectness, and face-work. While earlier perspectives often emphasized essential differences between male and female speech, more contemporary frameworks view gender as fluid, socially constructed, and contextually performed. This section explores the theoretical conceptualization of gender and how gender interacts with politeness strategies, drawing on foundational and modern contributions to the field.

2.4.1 Gender

The study of gender in language has shifted from a binary and static model to a more dynamic and socially constructed framework. Rather than treating gender as an inherent trait determined solely by biological sex, contemporary linguists view it as a product of social roles, discursive practices, and repeated performance.

Brody and Hall (2008) emphasized that gender is enacted through language, and speakers internalize different linguistic forms based on gender socialization. From childhood, boys and girls are often taught to value different interactional goals-competition and independence for boys, cooperation and connection for girls-which, over time, shape distinct communicative styles.

Tannen (1990) argued that men and women belong to different "subcultures" with distinct conversational goals and conventions. According to Tannen, women often prioritize rapport-building, empathy, and mutual support, whereas men focus

on status, information exchange, and control. These orientations lead to different uses of politeness: Women may use more indirect or face-saving strategies to maintain harmony, while men may opt for directness to assert dominance or efficiency.

However, these generalizations have been critically examined. Hyde (2005), through her Gender Similarities Hypothesis, analyzed hundreds of studies and concluded that most gender differences in communication are minor to negligible. She argued that individual, social context, and a woman's relations play a greater role than gender. Hyde's findings encourage a cautious and evidence-based approach to interpreting gender differences in politeness, avoiding overgeneralized or deterministic conclusions.

Thus, while gender may influence politeness strategies, it does so through social expectations, interactional norms, and context-specific roles rather than fixed binary traits. This evolving understanding provides more women's for examining how politeness functions in gendered communication.

2.4.2 Gender and Politeness Strategies

The relationship between gender and politeness strategies reflects how language shapes and is shaped by social norms and gendered identities. One of the most influential early contributions to this field is Lakoff's (1975) introduced a set of linguistic features that she associated with women's language-such as hedges (*sort of, maybe*), tag questions, indirect requests, and intensifiers. Lakoff argued that these features reflect women's subordinate social position and their need to express deference and avoid confrontation. This framework, commonly called the "*deficit model*", proposed that women's language was deficient compared to men's. However, it also opened the door for further inquiry into how gender is linguistically performed.

Building on this foundation, Tannen (1990) proposed the difference theory suggesting that men and women are socialized into distinct "*genderlects*". Tannen's work shifted the focus from deficiency to divergence, framing male and female communicative styles as equally valid but culturally different. According to Tannen, women use language to build rapport, foster intimacy, and support others, often employing indirectness, politeness, and collaborative discourse strategies. In contrast, men often prioritize status, independence, and the exchange of factual information, favoring more direct and competitive language styles. These contrasting goals result in different uses of politeness strategies and are often misinterpreted as communication problems between the sexes.

Holmes (1995) offered one of the most empirically grounded analyses of gendered politeness. Her findings show that women generally use more politeness strategies than men, including hedges, compliments, and minimal responses to signal active listening. Holmes argued that this trend does not indicate linguistic weakness but reflects women's relational orientation and a deliberate strategy to maintain social harmony. In the workplace, for example, Holmes observed that women are more likely to use compliments as "social lubricants" and to favor indirect speech acts that minimize imposition. Holmes emphasized that these tendencies are socially constructed, not biologically predetermined. She cautioned against assuming essential gender differences, noting that politeness varies

depending on power relations, role expectations, and situational context.

Holmes also stressed the double bind women often face: they are expected to be polite and deferential, but when they adopt assertive or direct speech-typically associated with male communication-they risk being judged as aggressive or unfeminine. This asymmetry reveals how politeness strategies are interpreted through the lens of gendered expectations, making women more vulnerable to criticism for linguistic behavior that deviates from social norms.

Other prominent scholars have expanded this discussion through alternative theoretical lenses. Eckert and McConnell-Ginet (2003) argued for a social constructionist view of gender, suggesting that gender is not an inherent property but a social identity actively constructed through discourse. They introduced the concept of communities of practice, emphasizing that gendered language use emerges through participation in specific social groups and practices. From this perspective, politeness strategies are not inherently male or female but are learned, negotiated, and performed within specific interactional and cultural contexts.

Mills (2003), working from a discourse and feminist pragmatics perspective, examined how gender, politeness, and power intersect. She criticized traditional politeness theory-particularly Brown and Levinson's-for its lack of sensitivity to gendered asymmetries in communication. Mills highlighted that women are often expected to be more polite and accommodating, and when they fail to conform to these expectations, they may be judged as impolite or deviant. She also pointed out that women's frequent use of hedges and indirectness is not merely a politeness strategy but also a survival mechanism in patriarchal structures, used to navigate and subtly resist hierarchical power relations.

Butler's (1990) theory of gender performativity offers a philosophical and radical reframing of gendered language use. Butler argued that gender is not something one "is" but something one "does"-a series of performed acts that, through repetition, create the illusion of a stable identity. In this view, language is a primary tool through which gender is enacted and maintained. From this standpoint, politeness strategies-such as hedging, indirectness, and deference-can be seen as linguistic choices and performative acts that produce gendered subjectivities. For example, a woman who repeatedly uses indirect speech acts may not only be fulfilling a social expectation but also enacting a gender identity recognized as "feminine" within her culture.

These perspectives reveal that politeness strategies are not neutral but deeply embedded in gender politics. Women's greater use of hedges and indirect forms may reflect socialization, power dynamics, or conscious rhetorical strategy, but such usage is always interpreted within a gendered framework. Moreover, with the rise of gender-inclusive and non-binary perspectives, modern sociolinguistics increasingly critiques the traditional male/female binary in politeness research, advocating for more inclusive and intersectional approaches to analyzing how language constructs social identity.

2.5 An Overview of the Film 'The Social Network' by David Fincher

Chosen for its dialogue-rich script and modern communicative context, David Fincher's 2010 film, 'The Social Network,' serves as the primary corpus for the

present study. Released on October 1st, 2010, the film was a significant cultural event, lauded by audiences for its sharp screenplay and direction (Fincher, 2010). It was also a critical success, ranked as one of the top ten films of the year by 78 critics (Metacritic, 2011). Its narrative, which portrays the founding of the social networking giant Facebook, resonates strongly with the contemporary digital era, making its dialogue a relevant reflection of modern communication patterns.

Based on Ben Mezrich's 2009 book *The Accidental Billionaires* (Mezrich, 2009), the film is a dramatized account of Mark Zuckerberg's life during the tumultuous creation of Facebook, focusing on the intense interpersonal conflicts, power dynamics, and legal battles that ensued. For the purposes of the present study, the film was chosen not only for its cultural relevance but primarily for its dialogue-rich script, penned by Aaron Sorkin (Fincher, 2010).

The narrative is driven by high-stakes conversations—including legal depositions, business negotiations, and personal confrontations—which provide a fertile ground for examining strategic linguistic choices. The interactions between male and female characters in these contexts of shifting power and status make it a particularly suitable case study for analyzing how hedging devices are employed from a gender perspective. Thus, 'The Social Network' serves as an ideal microcosm for investigating the pragmatic functions of hedging in modern, competitive communication.

2.6 Previous Studies

The study of hedging devices from a gender perspective has established a rich theoretical foundation, with notable works from both domestic and international scholars. An analysis of these studies highlights the diverse functions of hedging across different communicative contexts, thereby identifying the specific research gap that this project aims to address.

In the political context, the thesis by Tran (2019), "*A Study on Hedging Devices Used in Political Speeches of Hillary Clinton and Donald Trump*", employed a mixed-methods approach combining quantitative and qualitative discourse analysis. The findings revealed that Hillary Clinton tended to use hedges to express politeness and build consensus, whereas Donald Trump utilized them as a strategy to mitigate controversial statements. However, a limitation of this study is its focus on well-prepared political discourse, which differs significantly from spontaneous and immediate dialogue.

Shifting to an academic setting, the thesis by Le (2020), "*An Investigation into Hedging in Discussions of Male and Female Students*", applied a qualitative method by recording and analyzing group discussions. The results indicated that female students often used hedges to maintain harmony and encourage participation, while male students tended to use them to express epistemic uncertainty. The limitation of this work lies in its highly cooperative context among peers, where elements of competition and intense power conflict are largely absent.

Expanding to the international workplace, Holmes (2006) utilized ethnographic and discourse analysis methods on data from meetings in New Zealand. Her research showed that female leaders strategically used hedges to soften directives and encourage collaboration, while male leaders used them less frequently, except

to mitigate criticism. A limitation of this study is its focus on structured corporate environments where roles and power are pre-defined, and interactions often adhere to professional norms rather than complex personal relationships.

A more modern domain is online communication, analyzed in the study “*Predicting gender from electronic discourse*” by Thomson and Murachver (2001). Using quantitative analysis on online chat logs, this research found that women tended to use more tag questions and softening markers, while men used more assertive statements. However, a major limitation is that text-based communication lacks the non-verbal cues (intonation, facial expressions) and the immediacy of face-to-face dialogue, which are critical factors influencing the function of hedging.

Finally, in the context of entertainment, the thesis by Bui (2021), used pragmatic discourse analysis. The author concluded that female characters used hedges to build relationships, while male characters used them when joking. The inherent limitation of this study is its sitcom context, which is light-hearted and humorous, meaning hedges primarily serve comedic or affiliative purposes, not reflecting their use in tense conversations.

An overview of the aforementioned works reveals that, despite valuable analyses, a core research gap remains. Previous studies have largely been confined to predictable communicative contexts: formal political discourse (Tran, 2019), cooperative academic settings (Le, 2020), structured workplaces (Holmes, 2006), interactionally limited online communication (Thomson & Murachver, 2001), or light-hearted entertainment (Bui, 2021). The common limitation across these studies is the absence of an analysis of hedging within a context that simulates real-life interactions where competition, conflict, and fluid personal power dynamics are central. To the best of my knowledge, no study has examined how hedging is employed as a strategic rhetorical tool in modern dialogues characterized by high drama and struggle. It is from this gap that the project, “Hedging Devices in the Film *‘The Social Network’* (2010): Similarities and Differences from a Gender Perspective,” is undertaken.

CHAPTER 3. RESEARCH METHODOLOGY

3.1 Research Design

The present study uses a mixed-methods design, which means it combines both quantitative and qualitative approaches with two main goals: (a) to show what hedging devices are used by male and female characters in the film *'The Social Network'* (2010), and (b) to explain the communicative functions of these hedges in conversations. By combining the two approaches, the study aims to give both a broad overview and a deeper understanding of the topic.

On the quantitative aspect, the present study follows a descriptive design. Descriptive research is suitable when the purpose is to provide an objective, factual account of a phenomenon. In this approach, all hedging devices in the film are identified and grouped. The data are then counted and compared according to gender. These numbers help show the types of hedges male and female characters use.

On the qualitative aspect, the present study follows an analytical design based on discourse-pragmatic analysis. Qualitative research is useful for exploring how language is used and understood in context. After hedges are identified and counted, each one is examined to see its function in communication. The analysis looks at how hedges reduce threats to face, show uncertainty, soften disagreement, or build solidarity.

In general, the present study is designed as a case study. The case is one cultural product: The film *'The Social Network'*. A case study is appropriate when the goal is to study a phenomenon in detail within a boundary. The film is chosen because it offers natural dialogues that reflect real-life communication and because its content involves issues of power, status, and identity, situations where hedges are used.

The present study follows a sequential explanatory design. First, quantitative data are collected by coding all hedges in the dialogue extracts. This produces numerical results that show overall gender patterns. Next, qualitative analysis is used to explain these results in more detail.

This mixed-methods design strengthens the present study's validity and reliability. Quantitative data make the results more objective, while qualitative analysis adds depth by explaining meanings in context. Using both methods together increases the trustworthiness of the findings and provides a fuller picture of the phenomenon.

In summary, the study is a descriptive-analytical, mixed-methods case study. The quantitative approach shows the frequency and distribution of hedges, and the qualitative one explains their communicative roles. These approaches help answer the research questions fully and contribute to wider discussions about hedging, gender, and conversation.

3.2 Research Methods

In order to accomplish the aim and objectives of the research, the author used the following methods:

The *qualitative* and *quantitative* methods: The qualitative method was used to categorize and interpret the pragmatic functions of hedging devices within their specific conversational contexts. Furthermore, the qualitative analysis was supplemented by several methods used in linguistics, including context analysis and pragmatic analysis. The quantitative method, using statistical approaches, was used to enumerate and scrutinize the frequency of different types of hedging devices gathered from the data. I employed a mix of qualitative and quantitative methods to enhance the comprehensiveness of the investigation. -Quantificational hedges: approximators of quantity and frequency, such as *a lot, kind of, sometimes*.

A comparative analysis from a gender perspective was utilized to examine and differentiate the similarities and differences in the types and functions of hedging devices in male and female characters' utterances.

Descriptive and *Interpretive* methods: The use of descriptive and interpretive methods was deemed essential in order to adequately present and analyze the obtained results. The descriptive method was used to systematically present the collected data (e.g., the types and frequencies of the hedges), while the interpretive method was applied to analyze the underlying communicative strategies and pragmatic functions behind their use.

3.3 Data Collection

The primary data for this study is extracted from the official script of '*The Social Network*' (2010), written by Aaron Sorkin and directed by David Fincher. The film features approximately 120 minutes of fast-paced dialogue among characters of different gender, status, and interpersonal relationships, which provides a rich source for analyzing hedging behavior.

The transcript was manually segmented into distinct dialogue turns by each character. The characters were then grouped into two main gender categories: male (e.g., Mark Zuckerberg, Eduardo Saverin, Sean Parker) and female (e.g., Erica Albright, Marilyn Delpy, Gretchen).

From this corpus, the hedging devices were identified and categorized based on Yu's (2009) framework. Examples include five main categories:

-Modal hedges: including modal auxiliary verbs (*can, should, might*), adverbs (*maybe*), nouns (*chance*), adjectives (*likely*), and epistemic lexical verbs (*seems*).

-Performative hedges: verbs expressing a cognitive state, such as *I think, I know, I guess*.

-Pragmatic-marker hedges: discourse markers such as *you know, well, I mean*. -Others: including subjunctives (*if*), tag questions (*right?*), and impersonalization (*it seems*).

3.4 Data Analysis

3.4.1 Quantitative Analysis

In the quantitative stage, each identified instance of a hedging device was systematically coded and categorized according to two main criteria:

-*Type*: Based on the five-part taxonomy proposed by Yu (2009), including modal hedges, performative hedges, quantificational hedges, pragmatic-marker hedges, and others.

-*Gender of Speaker*: Male or Female.

The total number and percentage of hedges for each type were then calculated and compared across genders. This process allows the study to answer the first research question regarding the types and frequencies of hedges used.

It is important to note that a single utterance may contain one or more hedging devices. For the convenience of this quantitative analysis, the present study will identify each hedging device individually according to the classification model of Yu (2009) and did not investigate the co-occurrence or combination of these hedges.

A speaker can strategically combine a performative hedge (*I think*), a modal hedge (*should*), and a pragmatic marker (*just*) to significantly reduce the force of a direct statement. This layering technique is clearly demonstrated in the dialogue (1):

(1)

Mark (M) You don't have to study. You go to B.U. I'm not saying it's

not a real school, I'm just saying you're not likely to fail out and have to move back home to your parents' house, which you've never had to do.

Erica (F) I *think* we *should just* be friends.

Utterance (1) contains three distinct hedging devices. Each device is identified and classified independently as follows:

-*think*: This epistemic verb is classified as a performative hedge. As a cognitive verb, it explicitly states the speaker's mental state, framing the proposition "*we should just be friends*" not as a command or an objective fact, but as a personal opinion.

-*should*: This is classified as a modal hedge. As a modal auxiliary verb, "*should*" is used to offer advice or a suggestion rather than an obligation (like 'must') or a certainty (like 'will').

-*just*: This is classified as a pragmatic-marker hedge. In this context, "*just*" functions as a discourse marker that downplays the significance or complexity of the proposed action.

3.4.2 Qualitative Analysis

Following the quantitative identification of hedging devices, the qualitative stage involves a discourse-pragmatic analysis to interpret their communicative functions within the specific context of the dialogue. This analysis is guided by the synthesized theoretical framework drawing from the works of Lakoff (1975), Brown and Levinson (1987), Holmes (1995), and Hyland (1998). The goal is to understand *why* a character uses a particular hedge in a specific utterance. Specifically, to indicate the function of Solidarity/ Inclusiveness, “must” can be used, as in:

(2)

Marylin (F) You’re welcome to some salad.

Mark (M) No thank you.

Marylin (F) This *must* be hard.

Mark (M) Who are you?

In dialogue extract (2), the modal hedge “*must*” is interpreted as performing the function of *solidarity/inclusiveness*. “*Must*” is used to imply that the statement is not an assertion of a known fact (“This *is* hard”), but a strong inference based on observation. This is a hedging act, as Marilyn is not claiming to know Mark's internal feelings for certain, as in dialogue extract (2).

During a legal deposition, a lawyer states to Sean Parker that he is no longer with his previous company, Napster. The pragmatic marker “*Well*” can be used to perform *diplomatic avoidance*, especially when a speaker needs to delay or evade a direct answer, as in:

(3)

Eduardo (M) Wait, what is this?

Lawyer (M) *Well*, as you know we had some new investors--

Eduardo (M) What is this?

Lawyer (M) If you’ll let me--

The pragmatic-marker hedge “*well*” is not merely a filler word. Its function in this context is *diplomatic avoidance*. “*Well*” is often used to preface a statement that contradicts or disagrees with the previous speaker's assumption (a dis-preferred response). By using it, Lawyer signals a slight hesitation and manages the conversational flow, allowing him to concede a difficult point without appearing weak or overly defensive. It softens the bluntness of his admission and helps him maintain composure in a high-pressure situation.

This interpretive process is applied to the data to answer the second research question regarding the similarities and differences in the pragmatic functions of

hedges used by male and female characters.

3.5 Reliability and Validity

The study paid careful attention to both reliability and validity to make sure the results are trustworthy.

In terms of reliability, in the present study, reliability was ensured by using clear coding procedures to find and classify all hedging devices in the data. The coding scheme was adapted from well-known studies, which helped reduce personal bias and made the analysis easier to repeat. The data were also checked several times to limit mistakes and keep the results consistent.

As for validity, the study used both quantitative and qualitative methods. The quantitative part gave objective numbers on how often different hedges were used, while the qualitative part explained their communicative functions in context. Using these two approaches together (triangulation) made the results more convincing because they were supported in different ways.

Moreover, the choice of the film ‘The Social Network’ (2010) as the data source also contributed to validity. The film offers naturalistic dialogues that reflect authentic communication patterns, making it a reliable case for examining the use of hedging strategies in interaction.

In summary, by keeping the coding process consistent and using a mixed-methods approach, the study achieved both reliability and validity, ensuring the trustworthiness of its findings.

CHAPTER 4. FINDINGS AND DISCUSSION

This chapter presents a detailed analysis of the findings regarding hedging devices used in the film *'The Social Network'*, based on the classification model proposed by Yu (2009). Following the structure successfully employed in similar linguistic studies, this chapter will commence with a quantitative overview of the distribution of hedging devices. It will then proceed to a granular analysis of each category. Each section integrates quantitative data on frequency of use for each word/phrase, a gender-based analysis, citations of functions identified by previous researchers, and specific examples from the film's context to elucidate the similarities and differences in the linguistic strategies of male and female characters.

4.1 Hedging Devices Used by Male and Female Characters

According to Yu's (2009) model, there are five main hedging categories found out in the data from the film *'The Social Network'* (2010) as follows:

- (1) Modal hedges
- (2) Performative hedges
- (3) Quantificational hedges
- (4) Pragmatic-marker hedges
- (5) Others which include subjunctives, tag questions and impersonalization

The analysis of the data reveals an uneven distribution in the use of hedging categories, with the frequencies compiled and analyzed through a quantitative method.

4.1.1 Hedging Devices Used by Male Characters

Quantitative analysis reveals that the male characters are the predominant users of hedging devices in the film, accounting for 82.5% of the total with 284 instances. Table 4.1 presents the distribution of these tools across the five main categories from Yu (2009).

Table 4.1

Distribution of Hedges Used by Male Characters

Hedging Category					No	%
Modal hedges		126	44.4	Pragmatic-marker Hedges		45 15.8
		39	13.7	Performative Hedges		31 10.9
				TOTAL		284 100
				Others		43 15.1
				Quantificational Hedges		

Table 4.1 reveals an uneven distribution, indicating a deliberate linguistic strategy rather than random usage. Modal hedges are the most overwhelmingly used

group, accounting for 44.4% (126 instances). This suggests that modulating a proposition through modal verbs (such as *can*, *could*, *might*) is the core hedging strategy for the male characters.

Following at a significant distance are pragmatic-marker hedges at 15.8% and the others group, which includes structures like tag questions and hypotheticals, at 15.1%. These two groups, with their nearly equivalent frequencies, highlight the importance of both managing conversational flow and using rhetorical structures to assert a point.

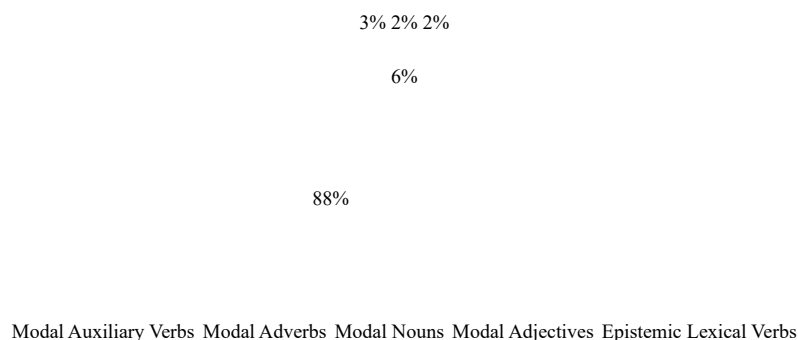
Finally, quantificational hedges and performative hedges are the two least used groups, at 13.7% and 10.9% respectively. The lower frequency of these categories suggests that providing numerical ambiguity or openly stating a cognitive state ("*I think*," "*I believe*") are less prioritized strategies in the communicative style of the male characters in the film.

4.1.1.1 Modal Hedge

With 126 occurrences (44.4%), modal hedges are the most frequently used hedging group by male characters. The distribution of sub-types within this group is uneven, showing a clear preference for certain linguistic tools. Figure 4.1 illustrates this distribution:

Figure 4.1

Distribution of Modal Hedges Sub-types Used by Male Characters



As Figure 4.1 demonstrates, modal auxiliary verbs account for an overwhelming proportion at 88%. This dominance indicates that the hedging strategies of male characters rely primarily on the most core and common grammatical tools (*can*, *should*, *may*, *etc.*). The modulation of meaning is performed at the basic sentence structure level, suggesting a hedging style that is tightly and frequently integrated into their dialogue.

Following this, epistemic lexical verbs make up a significantly smaller portion (2%), used to deliver sense-based judgments. The remaining sub-types such as modal adverbs, modal adjectives, and modal nouns are used with very low frequency (2-3%), showing that they are only secondary hedging tools in the communicative style of the male characters in the film.

As the data indicates, male characters primarily rely on core modal auxiliaries to hedge their statements, with “*can*” being one of the most common choice (58 occurrences), as in:

(4)

Mark (M) You *can* see why it’s so important to get in.

Erica (F) Okay, well, which is the easiest to get into?

Mark (M) Why would you ask me that?

In the utterance (4), the modal verb “*can*” is identified as the hedging device.

According to Yu's (2009, p. 110) classification, it is categorized as a modal hedge.

4.1.1.2 Pragmatic-marker Hedge

With 45 occurrences, pragmatic-marker hedges are the second most-used group by male characters. This group is divided into two main sub-types: interpersonal and propositional pragmatic-marker hedges with 31.1% (n=14) and 68.9% (n=31) respectively. This distribution of the pragmatic-markers hedges is illustrated in Table 4.2.

Table 4.2

Frequency of Subcategories Of Pragmatic-marker Hedges Used By Male Characters

Hedging devices No % Sum

INTERPERSONAL PRAGMATIC-MARKER HEDGE

Interpersonal

pragmatic-

you know/as you 78.6

marker hedges:

know 11

31.1%

do you know 1 7.1

Items: 3

do you think 2 14.3

Tokens: 14

Subtotal 14 100

PROPOSITIONAL PRAGMATIC-MARKER HEDGE

Subset 1: Precaution against or correction for potential

misconception

In fact 2 100

Subtotal 2 100

Subset 2: Precondition or prerequisite

Subtotal 0 0

Subset 3: exemplifying; explanatory

like

Propositional 10 100

pragmatic-

Subtotal 10 100

marker hedges:

Subset 4: Basis for judgments; speaker as source of information;

68.9%

attitudinal

Items: 5

well 10 52.6

Tokens: 31

I mean 6 31.6

It mean/that doesn't 15.8

mean 3

Subtotal 19 100

Subset 5: Hearer as source of information

Subtotal 0 0

Subset 6: Correction or further explanation

Subtotal 0 0

TOTAL: 45 tokens

a. Interpersonal Pragmatic-marker Hedge

Male characters use 13 instances of markers from this group. According to Yu (2009), these are hedges that function to create a sense of cooperation, sharing, or solidarity between conversational participants. In the data, the phrase “*you know*” is overwhelmingly dominant, accounting for 11 of the 13 occurrences.

Tag questions such as “*right?*” function as interpersonal pragmatic-marker hedges, used to frame information as shared knowledge and build solidarity, as in:

(5)

Mark (M) Yes, all behind a Pix Firewall Emulator. But here's the
beauty.

Eduardo (M) You know I didn't understand anything you just said,
right?

Mark (M) I do know that.

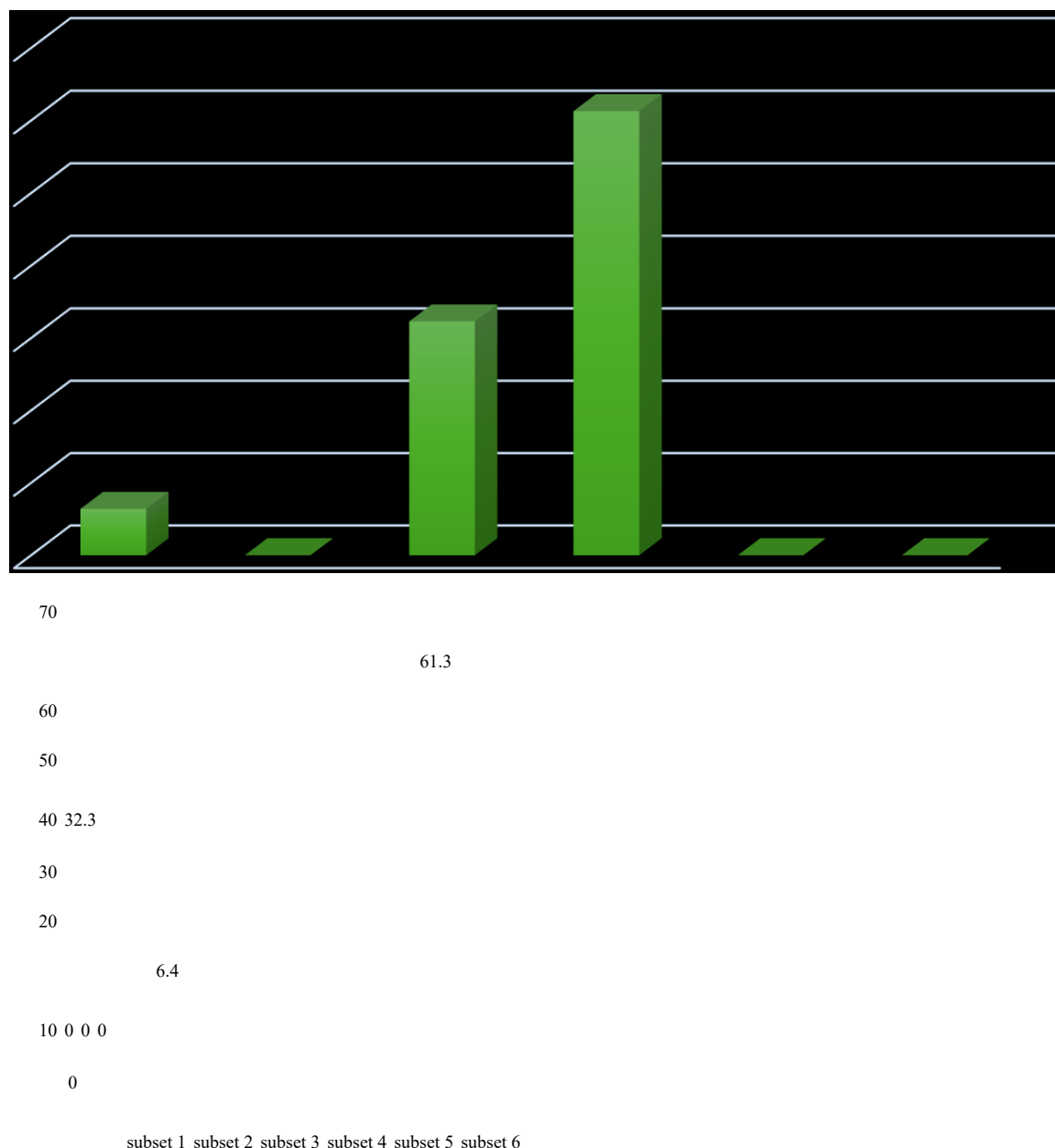
In utterance (5), the phrase “*right?*” is identified as a pragmatic-marker hedge. According to Yu's (2009, p. 148) framework, it is classified as such because it functions as a discourse marker separate from the propositional content. The speaker's preliminary purpose is to seek the listener's implicit agreement and to frame the information as shared knowledge, thereby softening the assertiveness of the claim.

b. Propositional Pragmatic-marker Hedge

This sub-type is used 32 times by male characters. According to Yu (2009), propositional pragmatic-markers are divided into six subsets with specialized functions: (1) precaution against misconception, (2) precondition, (3) exemplifying/explanatory, (4) basis for judgments, (5) hearer as a source of information, and (6) correction or further explanation. The Figure 4.2 illustrates the overall distribution of these subsets in the entire film.

Figure 4.2

Distribution of Subsets of Propositional Pragmatic-Marker Hedges Used by Male Characters



An analysis of the data exclusive to male characters reveals a clear concentration. Male characters do not use hedges from Subsets 2, 5, and 6. Instead, they most frequently use hedges belonging to Subset 4 (Basis for judgments; speaker as source of information; attitudinal), with 15 occurrences. This is the group of hedges

that helps speakers deliver judgments or express attitudes. This is followed by Subset 3 (Exemplifying; explanatory) with 10 occurrences, used for giving examples or explanations. Finally, Subset 1 (Precaution against or correction for potential misconception) is used 2 times.

Dialogue extract (6) illustrates the use of "*Well*" as a propositional pragmatic-marker hedge that introduced an important disclosure.

(6)

Amy (F) What was your latest preneur?

Sean (M) *Well*...I founded an internet company that let folks download
and share music for free.

Amy (F) Kind of like Napster?

Sean (M) Exactly like Napster.

In dialogue extract (6), the word "*Well*..." is identified as the hedging device. It is classified as a propositional pragmatic-marker hedge because it does not alter the proposition's factual content. Instead, it functions as a discourse marker that prefaces the main statement.

4.1.1.3 Quantificational Hedge

Ranking fourth in frequency of use is the quantificational hedges group, with 39 occurrences, accounting for 13.7% of all hedges used by men. These are words or phrases used to approximate a quantity, degree, or frequency rather than giving a precise number. Interestingly, the data reveals that male characters in the film avoid using frequency approximators and degree approximators entirely, concentrating their usage on other forms of quantification.

a. Quantity Approximator

As defined by Yu (2009, p. 141), these are words or phrases used by speakers to express an approximation of quantity, degree, or frequency without committing to a precise value. Their function is to make numerical values "*fuzzy*," and they serve as a form of quantificational hedges. In the analyzed data, this sub-type is absolutely dominant within the group, accounting for 38 out of the 39 instances recorded from male characters. This indicates that the male characters employed a diverse range of approximators to describe scale and quantity, as detailed in Table 4.3:

Table 4.3

Distribution of Quantity Approximators Used by Male Characters

Hedging Devices N° %	
A lot	8 2.8
some	6 2.1
A little	6 2.1
Kind of/kinda	5 1.8
much	3 1.1
A couple of	3 1.1
A little bit	2 0.7
about	2 0.7
A few	2 0.7
Around	1 0.4
SUBTOTAL	38 13.4
TOTAL	284 100

Table 4.3 details the distribution of these specific approximators. To illustrate the overall contribution of each device to the male characters' complete hedging toolkit, the following percentages are calculated relative to the total of 284 hedges identified.

The data shows a diversity in lexical choice, with "a lot" being the most frequently used device, accounting for 2.8% of all male hedges. This is followed by "some" and "a little", each contributing 2.1%. Additionally, the male characters utilize a range of other approximators with lower frequency, including "kind of/kinda" (1.8%), along with "much" and "a couple of" (each accounting for 1.1%). The diverse use of these devices indicates a deliberate linguistic strategy to avoid commitment to the absolute precision of information, thereby creating flexibility in conversation.

The use of a quantity approximator to create flexibility is shown in utterance (7).
(7)

Mark (M) Lowell has *some* security. They require a

username/password combo and I'm going to go ahead and say they don't have access to main FAS user database, so they have no way of detecting an intrusion.

In utterance (7), "*some*" is identified as the hedging device. It is classified as a quantificational hedge, specifically a quantity approximator, under Yu's (2009, p. 141) framework.

It is classified as such because *some* is used to refer to an indefinite quantity or degree. Instead of providing a specific assessment of the security's strength (e.g., "strong" or "weak"), Mark merely acknowledges its existence to an unspecified extent. The preliminary purpose of this hedge is to convey information without committing to the absolute accuracy of the assessment, which allows the speaker to be cautious and avoid the risk of making an incorrect judgment.

b. Negation + Intensifier Approximator

This sub-type appears only once, indicating it is a very specialized hedging tool is *not technically* (1 occurrence), as in: (8)

Amy (F) You're a zillionaire.

Sean (M) *Not technically*.

Amy (F) What are you?

Sean (M) Broke. There's not a lot of money in free music. Even

less when you're being sued by everyone who's ever been to the Grammys.

In utterance (8), the phrase "*not technically*" is identified as the hedging device. It is classified as a quantificational hedge under Yu's (2009) framework.

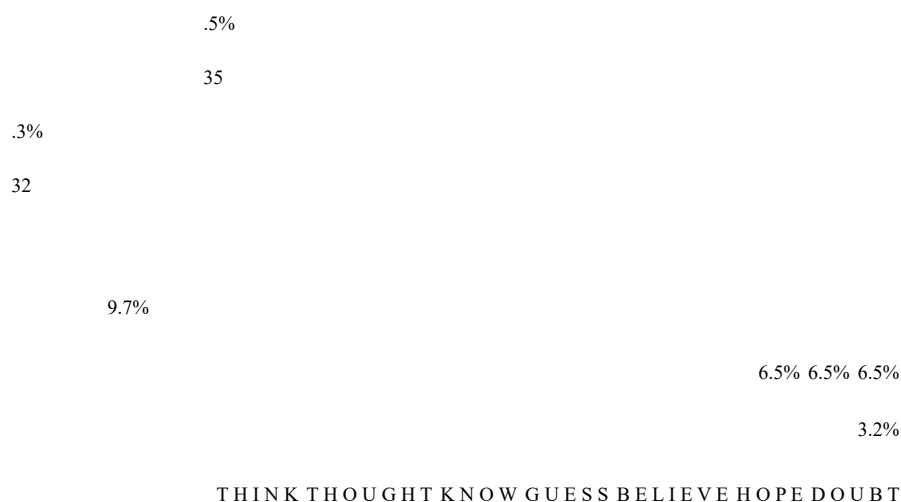
It is classified as such because *technically* functions as an approximator that restricts the scope of the negation "Not." It is not an absolute denial ("No"), but rather a denial that is true only within a narrow, "technical" context. *a. Subjunctive*

4.1.1.4 Performative Hedge

With 31 occurrences (accounting for 10.9%), performative hedges are the least frequently used group by male characters. These are verbs that explicitly state the speaker's cognitive state. The distribution of these verbs is shown in Figure 4.3.

Figure 4.3

Distribution of Performative Hedges Used by Male Characters



As Figure 4.3 shows, male usage is primarily concentrated on two main verbs: *know* (35.5%) and *think* (32.3%). The dominance of these two verbs indicates that when male characters use performative hedges, they often do so for two main purposes: either to assert knowledge with certainty (*know*) or to present a viewpoint as a personal thought (*think*). The remaining verbs such as *thought*, *guess*, *believe*, *hope*, and *doubt* are used with much lower frequency, suggesting they are only

situational tools.

In addition to the dominant verbs *know* and *think*, male characters also employ other performative hedges with lower frequency to state their cognitive position, such as "*guess*", as in:

(9)

Sy (M) Why don't we stretch our legs for a minute, can we do

that? It's been almost three hours and frankly you did spend an awful lot of time embarrassing Mr. Zuckerberg with the girl's testimony from the bar.

Mark (M) I'm not embarrassed, she just made a lot of that up.

Gretch (F) She was under oath.

en

Mark (M) Then *I guess* that would be the first time somebody's lied
under oath.

The utterance (9) contains the phrase "*I guess*," which is identified as the hedging device. Based on Yu's (2009, p. 127) theoretical framework, it is categorized as a performative hedge.

This classification is based on "*I guess*" being a cognitive verb that performs the speech act of 'guessing.' Instead of directly accusing someone of lying ("You are lying"), Mark frames his serious accusation as a personal inference. The preliminary purpose of this strategy is to deliver a powerful attack without taking full responsibility for its factual accuracy, thereby creating a formal layer of safety for a highly confrontational statement.

4.1.1.5 Others

The final group, Others, is used 43 times by male characters, accounting for 15.1%. This is a diverse group that includes various grammatical and rhetorical structures, divided into three main sub-types: subjunctives, tag questions, and impersonalization.

This sub-type is used by men to construct hypothetical arguments or scenarios, primarily using two words: *if* (17 instances) and *unless* (4 instances), as in:

(10)

Cameron (M) What my brother means is that *if* Mark Zuckerberg
walked into our dorm room and stole our computer that would be a university issue,
right?

In utterance (10), the word "*if*" is identified as the hedging device. Based on Yu's (2009) framework, it is classified under the "Others" category, specifically as a subjunctive.

It is classified as such because "*if*" introduces a subjunctive clause, establishing a hypothetical or non-factual scenario. The entire main clause that follows ("that would be an Ad Board issue") is only valid within the framework of this hypothetical condition.

b. Tag Question

These are short questions added to the end of a declarative statement. Male characters exclusively use *Right?* (13 instances) and *Okay?* (1 instance), as in:

(11)

Mark (M) People came to Facemash in a stampede, *right?*

In utterance (11), the hedging device is the tag question "*right?*". Instead of weakening the proposition, this hedge functions to reinforce it by compelling agreement. Under Yu's (2009) framework, it is classified in the "Others" category as a distinct syntactic structure.

c. Impersonalization

This sub-type includes sentence structures that begin with an impersonal subject (e.g., *it*, *this*) to present a judgment, as in:

(12)

Gage (M) From Mark Zuckerberg to Tyler Winklevoss. November

30, 2003. "I read over all the stuff you sent me re Harvard Connection and *it seems* like it shouldn't take too long to implement, so we can talk about it after I get all the basic functionality up tomorrow night.

In utterance (12), the construction "*It seems*" serves as the hedging instrument. Following Yu's (2009) framework, it is classified under the "others" category as a form of impersonalization.

This categorization stems from the speaker's use of an impersonal subject, "*It*," instead of a personal one (e.g., "*I think...*"). This technique creates distance between the speaker and their judgment. The preliminary purpose of this strategy is to present a highly subjective opinion ("*this is a revenge suit*") as if it were an objective, evidence-based observation. This makes the assessment appear more credible and less like a personal attack, a crucial tactic in legal discourse.

4.1.2 Hedging Devices Used by Female Characters

In contrast to their male counterparts, female characters use hedging devices with significantly lower frequency, accounting for only 17.5% of the total with 60

occurrences. Table 4.4 illustrates the distribution of these linguistic tools, which, in turn, reveals a distinctly different set of communicative strategies.

Table 4.4

Distribution of Hedges Used by Female Characters

Hedging Category	N°	%	Modal hedges	40	66.7	Pragmatic-marker Hedges	9	15	Others	2	3.3
			Quantificational Hedges	3	5	Performative Hedges	6	10			
TOTAL 60 100											

A point of similarity with the male characters is the dominance of modal hedges. This group accounts for a remarkable 66.7% (40 instances) of the total hedges used by female characters. This overwhelming proportion indicates that, like their male counterparts, modulating an utterance through modal verbs is the most foundational hedging strategy.

However, the divergence begins to appear in the remaining categories. pragmatic-marker hedges rank second at 15% (9 instances), highlighting the importance of managing conversational flow and interpersonal relationships. This is followed by performative hedges at 10% (6 instances), suggesting that framing a proposition as a personal opinion ("*I think*," "*I guess*") is also a relatively common strategy.

The most pronounced difference lies in the final two categories. Female characters make minimal use of quantificational hedges (5.%) and almost no use of the "others" category (3.3%). This indicates that creating numerical ambiguity or employing rhetorical structures like tag questions and hypotheticals is not a significant part of their communicative toolkit. Overall, the female characters employ a more narrowly focused hedging strategy, centering primarily on expressing possibility, making suggestions, and managing interaction.

4.1.2.1 Modal Hedge

With 40 instances, modal hedge is still the most used group by female characters, accounting for 66.7% of their total hedges. However, their choice of tools differs from men, focusing on verbs that express suggestions and possibilities politely. To visualize the concentration on certain tools, Figure 4.4 details the percentage of each modal hedges sub-type used by female characters.

Figure 4.4

Distribution of Modal hedges Sub-types Used by Female Characters

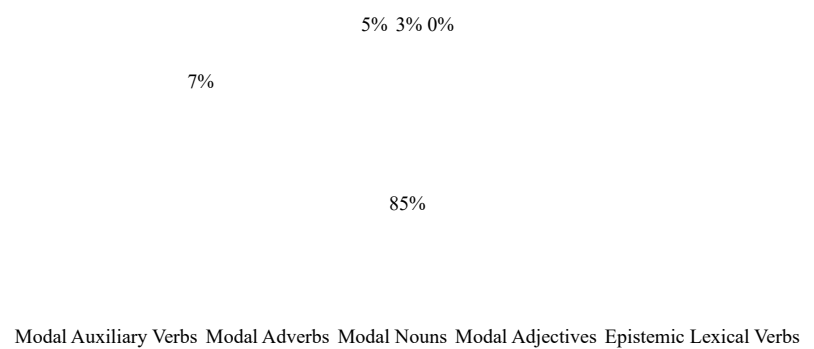


Figure 4.4 shows that modal auxiliary verbs are overwhelmingly the most used type by female characters, accounting for 85% (34 out of 40 instances) of the modal hedges group. This dominance indicates that their hedging strategy relies almost entirely on core grammatical tools like *can*, *should*, and *could*. Ranking second, modal adverbs are used with much lower frequency, accounting for 7.5% (3 instances). Following this with a very small share are modal nouns with 5% (n=2) and modal adverbs, accounting for approximately 2.5% (1 instance). Most notable is the complete absence of one sub-types. The data shows that female characters do not use epistemic lexical verbs, as well as *might* and *must*. This focused selection indicates a distinctly different hedging toolkit compared to male characters, as in:

(13)

Marylin (F) *Can* we establish a timeline?

In utterance (14), the modal verb "*Can*" is identified as the hedging device. Based on Yu's (2009) framework, it is categorized as a modal hedge.

It is classified as such because "*can*" is a modal auxiliary verb. Instead of issuing a direct and potentially imposing command (e.g., "Establish a timeline"), Marilyn uses "*can*" to frame her directive as a question of possibility or ability ("are we able to?").

4.1.2.2 Performative Hedge

Ranking third among the hedge types used by women is performative hedges, with six occurrences, accounting for 10% of the total. These are verbs that explicitly state the speaker's cognitive state, framing an utterance as a personal opinion or judgment.

The re-verified data shows that female characters use a range of performative verbs to express different degrees of certainty. Table 4.5 details the frequencies of performative hedges.

Table 4.5

Distribution of Performative Hedges Used by Female Characters

Hedging Devices N° %

think 3 5 know 1 2 guess 1 2 imagine 1 2

SUB TOTAL 6 10

TOTAL 60 100

Table 4.5 shows the distribution of verbs within this group. The data indicates a clear concentration on the verb "*think*", which accounts for half of the usage in this category with 3 occurrences. This suggests that when female characters employ

performative hedges, their primary strategy is to present a viewpoint as a personal thought, thereby reducing its imposing nature and creating space for dialogue.

The remaining verbs, such as "*know*," "*guess*," and "*imagine*," each appear only once. The presence of these verbs demonstrates a diversity in expressing different cognitive states, from softly asserting knowledge ("*I know that*") to offering a conjecture ("*I guess...*").

Overall, while not the most frequently used category, the preference for '*think*' reveals a communicative strategy aimed at reducing the assertiveness of an utterance and inviting collaboration, which aligns with interactional and relational functions, as in:

(14)

Eduardo (M) He's not a god.

Eduardo (M) What is he?

Christy (F) 25 minutes late.

Eduardo (M) *I think* Wardo's jealous.

In utterance (14), the phrase "*I think*" is the hedging device. It is classified as such under Yu's (2009) framework because it is a cognitive verb that makes the speaker's mental state explicit. Rather than definitively and perhaps imposingly stating, "Wardo is jealous," Christy frames this sensitive observation as a personal thought.

4.1.2.3 Pragmatic-Marker Hedge

With 9 occurrences, female characters show a preference for markers that function to clarify and assert with evidence, especially those they use exclusively. Table 4.6 illustrates the frequency of pragmatic-marker hedges used by female characters.

Table 4.6

Frequency of Subcategories Of Pragmatic-Marker Hedges Used By Female Characters

Hedging devices No % Sum

INTERPERSONAL PRAGMATIC-MARKER HEDGES *Interpersonal*

you know/as you know 1 50 *pragmatic-maker* do you know 1 50 *hedges: 22.2% Subtotal 2 100*
Items: 2

Tokens: 2

PROPOSITIONAL PRAGMATIC-MARKER HEDGES

Subset 1: Precaution against or correction for potential misconception

Subtotal 0 0 Subset 2: Precondition or prerequisite

Subtotal 0 0 **Subset 3:exemplifying; explanatory**

like 1 100 **Propositional** Subtotal 1 100 **pragmatic-marker Subset 4:Basis for judgments; speaker as source of information; hedges: 77.8% attitudinal Items: 3 well 3 50 Tokens: 7** It mean/ that doesn't 50 mean 3 Subtotal 6 100 **Subset 5: Hearer as source of information**

Subtotal 0 0 **Subset 6:Correction or further explanation**

Subtotal 0 0

TOTAL: 9 tokens

Table 4.6 provides a detailed breakdown of the 9 instances of pragmatic-marker hedges used by female characters, revealing a clear strategic preference. The data shows that usage is overwhelmingly skewed towards propositional pragmatic-marker hedges, which account for a dominant 77.8% of the total (7 tokens), compared to the much less frequent interpersonal pragmatic-marker hedges (22.2%, 2 tokens).

Within the dominant propositional category, usage is highly concentrated in subset 4 (basis for judgments; attitudinal), which comprises 6 of the 7 tokens through the equal use of “well” (3 instances) and “I mean/ that doesn’t mean” (3 instances). a single use of “like” from subset 3 (exemplifying; explanatory) completes this category. Notably, the complete absence of hedges from subsets 1, 2, 5, and 6 is a significant finding, indicating that female characters in the film do not use these markers to correct speech, set preconditions, or seek external information. This focused pattern suggests a communicative style that prioritizes the expression of personal judgments and attitudes over other pragmatic functions.

a. Interpersonal Pragmatic-marker Hedge

Female characters use 2 instances of markers from this group. According to Yu (2009), these are hedges that function to create a sense of cooperation and sharing. Each type (*you know/as you know, do you know, do you think*) in this group appears only once, as in:

(15)

Mark (M) Or I can get into a final club.

Erica (F) *You know*, from a woman's perspective, sometimes not
singing in a Capella group is a good thing?

Mark (M) This is serious.

The utterance (15) is particularly complex as it contains multiple layers of hedging. But “*You know*” is an interpersonal pragmatic-marker hedge. It does not alter the propositional content but functions as a tool to preface the utterance, engage the listener, and create a sense of shared knowledge. *b. Propositional Pragmatic-marker Hedge*

This sub-type is used 7 times by female characters. These are markers used to comment on the content of the proposition, often to explain, give examples, or as a basis for a judgment.

An important finding is that female characters only use hedges from two of Yu's (2009) six subsets which have mentioned in the previous part. The greatest concentration is on subset 4 (basis for judgments; speaker as source of information; attitudinal), with 6 out of 7 occurrences. this group includes the words/phrases *well* (3 times), *that mean* (1 time), and that *supposed to mean* (2 times). subset 3 (exemplifying; explanatory) appears only once with the word *like*.

Notable is the complete absence of subset 2 (precondition or prerequisite), subset 5 (hearer as source of information), and subset 6 (correction or further explanation). this indicates that the female characters in the film do not use hedges to set preconditions, rely on hearsay, or repair their own speech, as in: (16)

Mark (M) You can see why it's so important to get in.

Erica (F) Okay, *well*, which is the easiest to get into?

Mark (M) Why would you ask me that?

In utterance (16), "*well*" is more than a filler; it is a conversational pivot. It is classified as a propositional pragmatic-marker hedge under Yu's (2009) framework because it precedes and comments on the forthcoming proposition (the question "which is the easiest to get into?").

Instead of asking abruptly, the use of "*well*" signals a thoughtful pause, suggesting that her question is a considered response after having listened to (though perhaps disagreeing with) Mark's explanation.

4.1.2.4 Quantificational Hedge

The use of the quantificational hedges group by female characters is very rare, with only 3 occurrences, accounting for 5.0% of their total hedges. unlike men, they do not focus on approximating quantity, but use both quantity and frequency approximators (1 instance each). notably, they do not use degree approximators or negation + intensifier approximators, as in:

(17)

Sean (M) I went to check my e-mail and there's a site open on
your computer.

Amy (F) After you passed out last night I went on the Facebook
for a *little bit*.

Sean (M) What's that?

In utterance (17), the phrase "*a little bit*" is the hedging instrument. It is classified as a quantificational hedge because its core function is to make the duration of the action ambiguous.

Instead of stating a specific length of time (e.g., "for 15 minutes"), Amy uses an approximator. This allows her to admit to the action (going on the Facebook) without committing to a detail that could be judged (e.g., for being on it too long). The preliminary purpose of this hedge is to downplay the extent of her action, making it seem casual and insignificant.

4.1.2.5 Others

The same with quantificational hedges, the use of this group is also very rare, with only 2 instances, and focuses on reactive and interpersonal tools such as *if* (1 occurrence), *okay?* (1 occurrence), as in:

(18)

Mark (M) You didn't ask me which one was the best one, you
asked me which one was the easiest one.

Erica (F) I was honestly just asking. *Okay?* I was just asking to
ask. Mark, I'm not speaking in code

Mark (M) Erica--

In utterance (18), the hedging device is the tag question "*Okay?*". Under Yu's (2009) framework, it is classified in the "others" category.

It is classified as such because "*Okay?*" is a syntactic structure appended to a declarative sentence to seek confirmation or empathy. Its preliminary purpose is not informational, but rather a plea for the listener's understanding. By adding "*Okay?*", Erica shifts the focus from the *content* of her previous question to her intent (which she claims was innocent), thereby attempting to de-escalate the conversational tension.

4.1.3 Similarities and Differences in the Use of Hedging Devices by Male and Female Characters

Based on the quantitative data presented in sections 4.1.1 and 4.1.2, this section will synthesize and compare the similarities and differences in the use of hedging devices by male and female characters. The analysis will first address the similarities in usage patterns before delving into the more prominent and significant quantitative differences.

Table 4.7

Distribution of Using Hedging Devices by Male and Female Characters

NN Hedging Category N Male Female % N %

1	Modal Hedges	126	44.4	40	66.7	2	Pragmatic-Marker Hedges	45	15.8	9	15	3	Others	43	15.1
2	3.3	4	Quantificational Hedges	39	13.7	3	5	5	Performative Hedges	31	10.9	6	10		

TOTAL 284 100 60 100

4.1.3.1 Similarities in the Use of Hedging Devices by Male and Female Characters

The most notable similarity between the two genders is the clear preference for modal hedges. This is the most frequently used hedging group by both male (126 instances, 44.4%) and female (40 instances, 66.7%) characters, accounting for the highest proportion of each gender's total hedge use. This suggests that modulating propositions through possibility and speculation is a foundational hedging strategy regardless of gender.

Furthermore, the hierarchical preference for the top two categories is also perfectly consistent. Both genders use modal hedges most often, followed by pragmatic-marker hedges. Following this, pragmatic-marker hedges rank second for both groups, comprising 15.8% of hedges used by men and a strikingly similar 15% used by women. This similarity in ranking patterns indicates a shared importance of both modulating propositions and managing discourse in conversation.

4.1.3.2 Differences in the Use of Hedging Devices by Male and Female Characters

Regarding the differences, the most prominent point is the absolute disparity in frequency. Male characters use hedges (284 instances) nearly five times more often than female characters (60 instances), positioning hedging as a predominantly male linguistic strategy in this film.

This male dominance becomes more acute in specific hedge categories. A stark contrast is seen in the "Others" category, which includes rhetorical tools like tag questions and hypotheticals. Men dedicate 15.1% of their hedging toolkit to this category (43 instances), whereas for women, it constitutes a mere 3.3% (2 instances). Similarly, Quantificational Hedges are a significant part of the male strategy at 13.7% (39 instances), but are used minimally by female characters at only 5% (3 instances). This data suggests that tools for coercive validation (*Right?*), hypothetical argumentation (*if*), and quantitative approximation are almost exclusively a male rhetorical toolkit.

Finally, the difference is most sharply illustrated at the micro-level. The data reveals a clear "division of labor": male characters are the sole users of tools like *might*, *must*, *Right?*, and the entire group of Epistemic Lexical Verbs. Conversely, female characters are the exclusive users of key pragmatic markers such as *I mean* and *in fact*. This quantitative comparison sets the stage for a deeper functional analysis in section 4.2.

4.2 Functions of Hedging Devices Used by Male and Female Characters

This section provides an in-depth analysis of the practical functions of hedging devices employed by the characters. The classification and analysis are guided by a theoretical framework synthesized from the foundational works of several prominent linguists. Specifically, the functional classification system is built upon the research of Lakoff (1975) on politeness principles, Brown and Levinson (1987) on politeness theory and face-threatening acts, Holmes (1995) on language and gender, and Hyland (1998) on the role of hedging in discourse. This synthesized model offers a comprehensive lens through which to interpret the diverse communicative purposes that hedges serve in the film's dialogue.

4.2.1 Functions of Hedging Devices Used by Male Characters

An analysis of the male characters' dialogue in *'The Social Network'* reveals a purposeful and varied use of hedging devices. Table 4.8 details the frequency and percentage of each identified hedging function.

Table 4.8

Frequency and Percentage of the Functions of Hedging Devices Used by Male Characters

Function of Hedge N° %		
Expressing Uncertainty	13	4.6
Politeness/Softening	48	16.9
Mitigating Face-Threatening Acts	39	13.7
Tentativeness/Open-mindedness	4	1.4
Solidarity/Inclusiveness	10	3.5
Strategic Vagueness	16	5.6
Persuasion Strategy	77	27.1
Hedging Knowledge/Evidentiality	54	19
Diplomatic Avoidance	12	4.2
Creating Space for Response	11	3.9
		TOTAL 284 100

The data shows that the most prominent and overwhelmingly used function is *persuasion strategy*, accounting for 27.1% (77 instances). This high percentage indicates that the primary goal of the male characters when using hedges is not to express hesitation, but to make their arguments, proposals, or requests sound softer and more acceptable, thereby increasing the likelihood of achieving their communicative goals.

Ranking second is the function of *hedging knowledge/evidentiality* at 19% (54 instances). This suggests that male characters frequently use hedges to create a safe distance from the absolute accuracy of information, allowing them to present ideas without full evidential commitment. This is followed by key social-interactional functions such as *politeness/softening* (16.9%) and *mitigating face-threatening acts* (13.7%).

One of the most noteworthy findings is the very low frequency of the *expressing uncertainty* function, at only 4.6% (n=13). This strongly challenges the common notion that hedging is primarily a marker of a lack of confidence. For these characters, hedging is clearly a more calculated tool than a passive reflection of a cognitive state.

The remaining functions, such as *tentativeness/open-mindedness* (1.4%) and *creating space for response* (3.9%), are used very rarely, indicating their communicative style is less focused on inviting collaboration or showing hesitation, and more oriented toward asserting control over the conversation.

The data clearly indicates that the male characters use hedges for purposes far beyond simply expressing uncertainty. Instead, hedges function as strategic communicative tools that serve various aims, particularly in the highly contentious and confrontational contexts depicted in the film.

4.2.1.1 Persuasion Strategy

As the most frequently used function, *persuasion strategy* accounted with 27.1% (n=77) is the most prominent role of hedging devices employed by the male characters. The function of hedging as a persuasion strategy is a concept most prominently articulated in the work of Hyland (1998), who reframed hedging as a strategic rhetorical tool used to make arguments more acceptable to an audience. This view also builds upon earlier politeness theories, such as that of Brown and Levinson (1987), where mitigating the force of an utterance is a key tactic for gaining hearer compliance. This function is predominantly realized through

performative hedges and modal hedges. Table 4.9 provides a detailed quantitative breakdown of the specific words and phrases used to perform this persuasive function, arranged by frequency.

Table 4.9

Frequency of Hedging Devices Used for Persuasion Strategy by Male Characters

Hedging Device N° %	
can	25 8.8
should	18 6.3
think	12 4.2
might	8 2.8
maybe	5 1.8
if	4 1.4
I believe	3 1.1
could	2 0.7
SUBTOTAL 77 27.1	
TOTAL 284 100	

As Table 4.9 clearly demonstrates, the male characters' persuasion toolkit is dominated by modal auxiliary verbs, with "*can*" (8.8%) and "*should*" (6.3%) alone accounting for over half of all instances. This is followed by the performative hedge "*think*" (4.2%), which aligns with the examples analyzed previously. This data reinforces that persuasion in the film's male dialogue is most often achieved by framing proposals as possibilities, suggestions, or personal opinions rather than direct commands.

a. I think

Used to soften a strong assertion and reduce its confrontational tone is a key politeness strategy identified by Holmes (1995), as in:

(19)

Erica (F) Although just because something's trite it doesn't make it any less-

Mark (M) I want to try to be straight forward with you and tell you that I *think* you might want to be a little more supportive. If I get in I'll be taking you...to the events, and the gatherings...and you'll be meeting a lot of people you wouldn't normally get to meet.

Erica (F) You would do that for me?

By using the performative hedge "*I think*," Mark frames a request as a personal opinion. Simultaneously, the modal hedge "*might*" reduces certainty. This combination creates a sophisticated persuasion strategy that is less imposing and more likely to be accepted.

b. Think maybe...

Transforms a command or urgent advice into a suggestive question, implying collaboration and inquiry. This is a highly effective negative politeness strategy that minimizes imposition on the listener, a key concept in the work of Brown and Levinson (1987), as in:

(20)

Eduardo (M) This is an awful lot of traffic. *Think maybe* we
should shut it down before we get into trouble.

Rather than stating "We have to shut it down," Eduardo uses "*Think maybe*." This phrasing turns a command into a suggestive, collaborative question, demonstrating respect for Mark's ultimate authority. He is attempting to persuade Mark to agree to a critical action without creating conflict.

4.2.1.2 Hedging Knowledge/Evidentiality

Ranking second at 19.0% (54 instances), this function is employed when a speaker wishes to express their epistemic stance towards a proposition (Hyland, 1998). By signalling a degree of uncertainty or creating a safe distance from the absolute accuracy of a statement, the speaker can present information cautiously, a key function identified in numerous pragmatic studies (Holmes, 1995; Salager-Meyer, 1994). They often employ quantificational hedges and performative hedges. Table 4.10 details the specific devices used.

Table 4.10

Frequency of Hedging Devices Used for Hedging Knowledge/Evidentiality by Male Characters

Hedging Device N° %	
I know	11 3.9
some	6 2.1
kind of/kinda	5 1.8
a lot	5 1.8
a little	4 1.4
I don't know	3 1.1
a couple of	3 1.1
much	3 1.1
probably	2 0.7
about	2 0.7
a few	2 0.7
a little bit	2 0.7
it seems	2 0.7
around	1 0.4
I thought	1 0.4
not technically	1 0.4
I'm not sure	1 0.4
SUBTOTAL 54 19	
TOTAL 284 100	

As shown in Table 4.10 , the performative hedge "*I know*" (3.9%) is the most dominant tool for this function, often used to assert knowledge while simultaneously framing it as a personal cognitive state. This is followed by a wide range of quantificational hedges like "*some*" (2.1%), "*kind of*" (1.8%), and "*a lot*" (1.8%), which allow speakers to make claims without committing to precise details.

a. Probably

Used to signal the speaker's epistemic stance toward the proposition, indicating a strong likelihood rather than an absolute certainty (Hyland, 1998), as in:

(21)

Mark (M) You got punched by the Phoenix.

Eduardo (M) It was, you know...it was *probably* just a diversity
thing. It was just a diversity thing.

In the utterance (21), the word "*probably*" indicates that Eduardo is not 100% certain of the reason he was selected. He is offering a conjecture, thereby downplaying his own achievement with a display of modesty. This is a way of hedging his knowledge of others' motivations, as in:

(22)

Gage (M) From Mark Zuckerberg to Tyler Winklevoss. November 30, 2003. "I read over all the stuff you sent me re Harvard Connection and *it seems* like it shouldn't take too long to implement, so we can talk about it after I get all the basic functionality up tomorrow night.

In utterance (22), the phrase "*it seems*" allows Mark to provide a time estimate without making a firm commitment. He is hedging the certainty of the timeline, creating a buffer for himself if the work takes longer while still keeping them engaged.

4.2.1.3 Politeness/Softening

Constituting 16.9% of the hedges (48 occurrences), politeness/softening is a core concept within Brown and Levinson's (1987) Politeness Theory, which posits that speakers use such devices to reduce the imposition of face-threatening acts. This relational function of hedging was further explored by Holmes (1995), who linked it to strategies for maintaining social harmony. This function is primarily achieved through pragmatic-marker hedges, quantificational hedges and modal hedges. Table 4.11 provides a quantitative breakdown of the specific tools employed.

Table 4.11

Frequency of Hedging Devices Used for Politeness/Softening by Male Characters

Hedging Devices N° %	
Just	10 3.5
you know	9 3.2
Can	7 2.5
Should	6 2.1
A little	2 0.7
I mean	2 0.7
Could	2 0.7
Right?	2 0.7
Well	1 0.4
I think	1 0.4
I was just saying	1 0.4
Maybe	1 0.4
Frankly	1 0.4
I wouldn't say	1 0.4
SUBTOTAL	48 16.9
TOTAL	284 100

The data in Table 4.11 reveals that the pragmatic markers "*just*" (3.5%) and "*you know*" (3.2%) are the primary tools used by male characters to soften their utterances. This is followed closely by the modal verbs "*can*" (2.5%) and "*should*" (2.1%). This distribution indicates a strategy of softening speech by either minimizing the imposition of a statement (with "*just*"), creating a sense of shared knowledge (with "*you know*"), or framing it as a suggestion or possibility (with "*can*" and "*should*")

a. Just

Used as a "down toner" that minimizes the imposition of a speech act is a politeness strategy extensively analyzed by Holmes (1995), as in:

(23)

Mark (M) You didn't ask me which one was the best one, you
asked me which one was the easiest one.

Erica (F) I was honestly *just* asking. Okay? I was just asking to
ask. Mark, I'm not speaking in code

Mark (M) Erica—

In utterance (23), the repetition of "*just*" emphasizes that her question lacks ulterior or aggressive motives. This is a clear attempt to soften the remark's impact and de-escalate tension, which is a polite conversational move.

b. A little

Used to reduce the intensity of a request or criticism is a classic softening strategy, a function extensively analyzed by Holmes (1995), as in:

(24)

Erica (F) Although just because something's trite it doesn't make it
any less—

Mark (M) I want to try to be straight forward with you and tell you

that I think you might want to be *a little* more supportive. If I get in I'll be taking you...to the events, and the gatherings...and you'll be meeting a lot of people you wouldn't normally get to meet.

Erica (F) You would do that for me?

In utterance (24), instead of saying "be more supportive," the addition of "*a little*" softens the request. It transforms potential criticism into a gentler piece of advice, making it less likely to provoke a defensive reaction from Erica.

c. Maybe

Presents a proposition as a mere possibility, which reduces the imposition on the hearer - a core negative politeness strategy as theorized by Brown and Levinson (1987). This softening function was also identified in the foundational work of Lakoff (1975), as in:

(25)

Eduardo (M) Very nice to meet you. Christy (F) Facebook me when you get home.
Maybe we can
all go out and grab a drink later.

Eduardo (M) Certainly. Absolutely I will do that.

In utterance (25), the word "*Maybe*" frames the invitation as a possibility rather than a direct proposal. This phrasing lessens the social pressure to accept, showing politeness and respect for the listener's autonomy.

4.2.1.4 Mitigating Face-Threatening Acts

This function, which accounts for 13.7% of the data (39 instances), is the central concept of Politeness Theory, famously developed by Brown and Levinson (1987). This function is particularly employed when a speaker must perform a speech act that could potentially damage the listener's "face" (e.g., their public self-image, feelings, or reputation), such as refusing, criticizing, commanding, or disagreeing. This function often combines specific lexical items with performative hedges and tag questions. Table 4.12 details the specific devices employed.

Table 4.12

Frequency of Hedging Devices Used for Mitigating FTAs by Male Characters

Hedging Device	N°	%
if	17	6
can	6	2.1
I think	4	1.4
would	3	1.1
could	3	1.1
should	2	0.7
I'm sorry	2	0.7
I apologize	1	0.4
unless	1	0.4

SUBTOTAL 39 13.7

TOTAL 284 100

The data overwhelmingly shows that the primary tool used by male characters to mitigate FTAs is the subjunctive hedge "*if*" (6%). This strategy allows them to frame a disagreement or a difficult point within a hypothetical scenario, reducing its directness. This is followed by a series of modal verbs like "*can*" (2.1%), "*would*" (1.1%), and "*could*" (1.1%), which further soften assertions by presenting them as possibilities rather than facts.

a. *I apologize/I'm sorry*

The most direct way to repair the damage caused by a prior face-threatening act (FTA). This concept of redressive action is a cornerstone of Politeness Theory, as developed by Brown and Levinson (1987), who analyzed apologies as a key strategy for addressing threats to the hearer's positive face, as in:

(26)

Erica (F) : Yes.

Mark (M) : Okay, then wait. *I apologize*, okay?

Erica (F) : I have to go study.

In utterance (26), this apology is a clear effort to mitigate the negative impact of his prior insults. Mark is attempting to salvage the situation and "repair" the damage done to Erica's face, which he has just threatened.

b. *I think we should...*:

Used to soften a directive by framing it as a collaborative suggestion, a classic negative politeness strategy that minimizes the imposition on the hearer (Brown & Levinson, 1987), as in:

(27)

Mark (M) : Because you go to B.U.! Erica (F) : *I think* we should just be friends. Mark (M) : I don't want friends.

In utterance (27), this is a classic euphemism for a breakup. Instead of saying "I'm breaking up with you," the phrase "*I think*" frames a unilateral decision as a joint proposal, aiming to lessen the emotional blow and shock for the listener.

4.2.1.5 Strategic Vagueness

Accounting for 5.6% (16 instances) of the total, the function of *strategic vagueness* is employed by male characters when they wish to conceal information, avoid committing to a specific course of action, or keep their options open. This function, viewed by Hyland (1998) as a strategic rhetorical move, allows speakers to be intentionally imprecise. This also aligns with the 'off-record' politeness strategies theorized by Brown and Levinson (1987), where ambiguity is used to mitigate face-threatening acts. In the film, this function is predominantly realized through indeterminate quantificational hedges. Table 4.13 details the specific devices used for this purpose.

Table 4.13

Frequency of Hedging Devices Used for Strategic Vagueness by Male Characters

Hedging Device N° %	
something	5 1.8
a couple of	3 1.1
a little bit	2 0.7
a little	2 0.7
some	2 0.7
kind of/kinda	1 0.4
about	1 0.4
SUBTOTAL 16 5.6	
TOTAL 284 100	

As the data illustrates, the primary tool for strategic vagueness is the indefinite pronoun "*something*" (1.8%). This is followed by a range of other quantity approximators like "*a couple of*" (1.1%). The reliance on these devices shows a clear strategy of using imprecise language to maintain flexibility, conceal specific intentions, or keep conversational options open.

a. *Something/Some...*

Used to be intentionally imprecise, a key rhetorical strategy for avoiding commitment as analyzed by Hyland (1998), as in:

(28)

Mark (M) I'm saying I need to do *something* substantial in order to get
the attention of the clubs.

In utterance (28), the phrase "*something*" is intentionally vague. Mark does not specify *what* he will do because he does not yet have a concrete idea, but it allows him to express the scale of his ambition without being tied to any specific plan.

b. *A couple of*

Used as a classic approximator, a category of hedges first systematically classified by Prince, Frader, and Bosk (1982) to describe words that make propositional content less precise, as in:

(29)

Eduardo (M) Who are you gonna send it to?

Mark (M) Just *a couple of* people. The question is, who are they
gonna send it to?

In utterance (29), the phrase "*a couple of people*" is strategically vague. It conceals his intent to distribute the site widely and makes propositional content less precise.

4.2.1.6 Expressing Uncertainty

The function of *expressing uncertainty* involves a speaker conveying a genuine lack of confidence in a proposition. This aligns with what Hyland (2005) categorizes as hedges that signal a writer's decision to "*withhold complete commitment to a proposition*" (p. 52), thereby showing a degree of doubt. This function is most directly realized through performative hedges. Table 4.14 provides a breakdown of the specific devices used.

Table 4.14

Frequency of Hedging Devices Used for Expressing Uncertainty by Male Characters

Hedging Device N° %

I don't know 6 2.1 I'm not sure 4 1.4 I mean 2 0.7 I guess 1 0.4

SUBTOTAL 13 4.6

TOTAL 284 100

The data clearly shows that when male characters express genuine uncertainty, they do so with a very limited set of direct phrases. The performative hedge "*I don't know*" (2.1%) is the most dominant tool, followed by "*I'm not sure*" (1.4%). Together, these two phrases make up over three-quarters of all instances, indicating a preference for direct and unambiguous statements of uncertainty rather than more

subtle or indirect hedges.

a. *I'm not sure:*

A direct way to express uncertainty or confusion, as in:

(30)

Erica (F) ...sometimes you say two things at once and *I'm not sure*

which one I'm supposed to be aiming at.

In utterance (30), Erica frankly admits her confusion. This is not a strategy but a genuine expression of her inability to follow his train of thought. She is hedging her own ability to comprehend.

b. *I don't know:*

Often used as a filler when a speaker is thinking or genuinely does not have an answer, as in:

(31)

Cameron (M) *I don't know*, a three hour low-rate technical row

before breakfast, a full course load, studying... *I don't know* how we missed it.

In utterance (31), Cameron repeats the phrase "*I don't know*" to emphasize his surprise and uncertainty as to how they could have missed such a major campus event.

(32)

Mark (M) That's not what happened... *I mean*--That's--back at the

bar with Erica Albright. She said all that?

In utterance (31), the hesitant filler "*I mean*..." and the incredulous question "She said all that?" reveal Mark's genuine surprise and uncertainty. This is not a strategy, but an authentic, confused reaction.

4.2.1.7 Diplomatic Avoidance

Accounting for 4.2% (12 instances), *diplomatic avoidance* is used by male characters to evade direct or accusatory questions. This function is realized through various forms, including performative hedges, modal hedges, and other rhetorical strategies. Table 4.15 details the specific devices used.

Table 4.15

Frequency of Hedging Devices Used for Diplomatic Avoidance by Male Characters

Hedging Device		N°	%
I'm not sure	3	1.1	
Would	3	1.1	
Well	1	0.4	
I think	1	0.4	
If	1	0.4	
I don't know	1	0.4	
Could	1	0.4	
I guess	1	0.4	
SUBTOTAL		12	4.2
TOTAL		284	100

The data shows a balanced use between the performative hedge “*I'm not sure*” (1.1%) and the modal verb “*would*” (1.1%) as the primary tools for *diplomatic avoidance*. This indicates a dual strategy: either claiming uncertainty about the question's motive (“*I'm not sure why you're asking me that*”) or reframing a statement hypothetically (“*I wouldn't say I approached him*”). The remaining devices are used only once, highlighting the situational and varied nature of this particular communicative function, as in:

(33)

Mark (M) *I'm not sure* why you're asking me that.

In utterance (33), the structure “*I'm not sure*” uses a verb describing the speaker's cognitive state. Instead of addressing the content of the question, Mark hedges by expressing uncertainty about the questioner's *motive*. This performative form allows him to skilfully redirect the conversation and avoid having to confirm a fact, as in:

(34)

Mark (M) *I wouldn't say* I approached him.

The most prominent element is the modal hedge “*wouldn't*”. In utterance (34), the modal verb *would* in its negative form creates a hypothetical situation (“if I had to describe it, that is not the word I would choose”). It distances Mark from the action of “approaching.” The performative element (“I say”) reinforces that this is his personal phrasing. This combination allows Mark to both evade the question and challenge the lawyer's interpretation.

4.2.1.8 Other Less Common Functions

The final three functions are *creating space for response*, *solidarity/inclusiveness*, and *tentativeness/open-mindedness*-collectively account for less than 9% of all hedges used. Though infrequent, they serve specific communicative purposes in certain contexts, revealing the diversity of the characters' linguistic strategies.

a. Creating Space for Response

Accounting for 3.9% (11 instances), *creating space for response* uses linguistic elements to invite the listener to participate in or agree with the conversation. Tag questions are usually used to present this function, as in:

(35)

Mark (M)--is exclusivity. (beat) *Right?*

In utterance (35), after stating his key point, Mark uses the tag question "*Right?*" to seek confirmation. This move directly invites their agreement and draws them into his line of reasoning.

b. Solidarity/Inclusiveness:

At 3.5% (10 occurrences), this function builds a sense of "we" and emphasizes a collaborative relationship, as in:

(36)

Mark (M) It *probably* was a diversity thing but so what?

In utterance (36), Mark is not simply agreeing; he is actively building a common ground with Eduardo, strengthening their partnership by siding with his friend and dismissing his self-doubt. This is a powerful way to build solidarity without needing to use the pronoun "we."

c. Tentativeness/Open-mindedness:

As the rarest function at only 1.4% (4 instances), this reflects a hesitant attitude or a willingness to consider other opinions-a trait seldom seen in the film's assertive characters, as in:

(37)

Eduardo (M) : You *think* this is such a good idea?

In utterance (37), instead of stating bluntly, "This is a bad idea," Eduardo phrases his concern as a question. This shows tentativeness and gives Mark space to defend his idea, demonstrating a (slight) openness to being persuaded.

4.2.2 Functions of Hedging Devices Used by Female Characters

In stark contrast to the male characters, the use of hedging devices by female characters in '*The Social Network*' reveals a different set of communicative priorities, focusing on relational and interactional functions. This analysis finds that the patterns in the film align with classic research in sociolinguistics by Coates (2004) and Lakoff (1975), who suggest that women's speech often features characteristics that support collaborative conversation and relationship maintenance.

Table 4.16 presents a quantitative breakdown of the pragmatic functions of hedging devices employed by the female characters, detailing both the frequency and percentage of their occurrence.

Table 4.16

Frequency and Percentage of the Functions of Hedging Devices Used by Female Characters

Function of Hedge N° %

Expressing Uncertainty	7	11.7	Politeness/Softening	11	18.3	Mitigating Face-Threatening Acts	21	35
Tentativeness/Open-mindedness	1	1.7	Solidarity/Inclusiveness	4	6.7	Strategic Vagueness	2	3.3
Persuasion Strategy	2	3.3	Hedging Knowledge/Evidentiality	4	6.7	Diplomatic Avoidance	0	0
Creating Space for Response	8	13.3	TOTAL	60	100			

The data shows that the overwhelmingly dominant function is mitigating face-threatening acts, accounting for 35% (21 instances). This high frequency indicates that the primary purpose of hedging for female characters is to soften utterances that could potentially cause conflict, such as refusals, criticisms, or disagreements. This reflects their frequent role of having to react within challenging communicative situations, using hedges as a strategic tool to navigate interactions safely and minimize confrontation.

The next most important functions further reinforce this relational communicative orientation. Politeness/softening accounts for 18.3%, and creating space for response makes up 13.3%. The prioritization of these functions demonstrates a communicative style focused on maintaining harmony, respecting the turns of others, and fostering a collaborative dialogue, rather than unilaterally imposing a viewpoint.

A noteworthy finding is that the function of *expressing uncertainty* accounts for only 11.7%. While present, it is not the primary reason for hedging, thereby challenging the stereotype that women's use of hedges stems mainly from a lack of confidence. In the context of the film, this uncertainty often reflects a genuine confusion when faced with the complex or aggressive discourse of the male characters.

Finally, the difference in communicative strategy is most clearly demonstrated by the functions that are almost never used. Proactive and strategic functions such as persuasion strategy (3.3%) and strategic vagueness (3.3%) have very low frequencies. Notably, the function of diplomatic avoidance is entirely absent (0%). This absence is significant, as it highlights that the narrative role of the female characters is not that of manipulators or evaders, but often that of direct questioners or confronters, forcing other characters to face the truth.

In summary, the functional analysis shows that the female characters use hedging devices as a "reactive and navigational" linguistic toolkit. Their strategies prioritize the management and maintenance of stability in social interactions, a stark contrast to the "proactive and controlling" toolkit employed by the male characters.

4.2.2.1 Creating Space for Response

Notably more frequent among female characters, *creating space for response* accounts for 13.3% (8 instances) and is used to invite dialogue and participation from the other person. Table 4.17 provides a quantitative breakdown of the specific devices employed.

Table 4.17

Frequency of Hedging Devices Used for Creating Space for Response by Female Characters

Hedging Device N° %

Should 3 5 Can 2 3.3 Would 2 3.3 Okay? 1 1.7

SUBTOTAL 8 13.3**TOTAL 60 100**

Table 4.17 clearly shows that this function is achieved almost exclusively through interrogative structures. The modal verb “*should*” (5%) is the most frequent tool, used to turn a suggestion into a question that requires a response (e.g., “*Should we get something to eat?*”). This is followed by “*can*” (3.3%) and “*would*” (3.3%), which similarly create obligatory conversational turns for the listener. The single use of the tag question “*okay?*” (1.7%) further underscores a communicative style aimed at seeking confirmation and encouraging listener participation.

(38)

Erica (F) *Should* we get something to eat?

In utterance (38), by posing a direct question, Erica forces Mark to stop and provide an answer. This action proactively creates a space for Mark to participate in the conversation as a partner, rather than as a lecturer. It opens up a new conversational turn and invites interaction, making it a perfect example of this function.

4.2.2.2 Hedging Knowledge/Evidentiality

Also used in 6.7% of cases (4 instances), the function of *hedging knowledge/evidentiality* signals that a statement is based on belief or inference rather than absolute fact. This aligns with the concept of expressing a speaker's epistemic stance, a core idea in Hyland's (1998) framework. Holmes (1995) further contextualizes this function in women's speech, noting that expressing epistemic uncertainty can also serve relational goals, such as appearing less assertive and inviting collaboration. The specific linguistic devices used to perform this function are presented in Table 4.18:

Table 4.18*Frequency of Hedging Devices Used for Hedging Knowledge/Evidentiality by Female Characters***Hedging Device N° %** Can't possibly 1 1.7 I think 1 1.7 Well 1 1.7 I guess 1 1.7**SUBTOTAL 4 6.7****TOTAL 60 100**

The data shows that this function is not dominated by a single device but is instead realized through a variety of distinct linguistic tools, with each hedge used only once. This includes the modal construction “*can't possibly*”, the performative hedges “*I think*” and “*I guess*”, and the pragmatic marker “*well*”. This diverse and

infrequent usage suggests that hedging knowledge is a highly situational and context-specific strategy for the female characters in the film, as in:

(39)

Erica (F) That *can't possibly* be true.

In utterance (39), this is a strong disagreement, but it is hedged. The modal hedge "*can't possibly*" does not present a counter-fact ("That's false"); rather, it presents her personal *assessment* of the proposition's truth value based on her own logic. It strongly challenges Mark's statement but leaves the door open for him to defend or explain his claim, rather than shutting down the conversation.

4.2.2.3 Politeness/Softening

Making up 18.3% of the total (11 occurrences, *politeness/softening* is used to ensure that interactions remain smooth and non-confrontational. This function is primarily realized through pragmatic-marker Hedges to maintain a harmonious conversation, as noted by Holmes (1995). Table 4.19 provides a quantitative breakdown of the specific devices employed.

Table 4.19

Frequency of Hedging Devices Used for Politeness/Softening by Female Characters

Hedging Device	N°	%	Just	3	5	Should	2	3.3	I was just saying	2	3.3	You know	1	1.7	well	1	1.7
			Could	1	1.7	maybe	1	1.7									
SUBTOTAL		11	18.3														
TOTAL		60	100														

Table 4.19 shows a clear preference for the pragmatic marker "*just*" (5%), which is used to minimize the imposition or perceived weight of a statement. This is followed by the modal verb "*should*" (3.3%) and the performative phrase "*I was just saying*" (3.3%), which both serve to frame utterances as gentle suggestions or simple observations rather than direct assertions. The use of these specific tools highlights a communicative strategy aimed at ensuring interactions remain cooperative and respectful, as in:

(40)

Erica (F) I was honestly *just* asking. Okay?

In utterance (40), the repetition of "*just*" serves to minimize the perceived weight of her question, reassuring Mark that there is no hidden attack. This is a classic softening tactic used to maintain conversational peace.

4.2.2.4 Mitigating Face-Threatening Acts

Accounting for a remarkable 35% (21 instances), *mitigating face-threatening acts* was by far the most dominant function. The female characters frequently find themselves in positions where they must deliver unwelcome news, disagree, or

refuse requests, and they use hedges extensively to soften these potentially damaging speech acts. This function is realized through a focused set of performative and modal hedges. Table 4.20 details the specific devices employed.

Table 4.20

Frequency of Hedging Devices Used for Mitigating FTAs by Female Characters

Hedging Device	N°	%
I think	3	5
should	3	5
I appreciate that	2	3.3
I'm sorry	2	3.3
just	2	3.3
but	2	3.3
a little bit	1	1.7
kind of/kinda	1	1.7
you know	1	1.7
well	1	1.7
could	1	1.7
if	1	1.7
I was just saying	1	1.7
SUBTOTAL	21	35
TOTAL	60	100

Table 4.20 details the 21 instances (accounting for 35%) that perform this function. The data reveals a distinct concentration on specific linguistic tools used to soften difficult messages. The most frequently used devices are the performative hedge "*I think*" (3 instances, 5%) and the modal hedge "*should*" (3 instances, 5%). Following closely is a group of key politeness devices such as "*I appreciate that*", "*I'm sorry*", "*just*", and "*but*", each accounting for 3.3%. The diversity of the other devices used (such as "*a little bit*", "*kind of/kinda*", "*well*", and "*if*") indicates that the female characters employ a range of linguistic strategies to minimize conflict, as in:

(41)

Erica (F) *I appreciate that* but--I have to study.

In utterance (41), Erica uses "*I appreciate that*" performs "face-work" by acknowledging the positive intent of Mark's action and validating his feelings. This creates a buffer.

This strategy, a textbook example of Brown and Levinson's (1987) "negative politeness," serves to minimize the harm to Mark's face. It reframes a personal rejection as a circumstantial obstacle, making the situation less confrontational.

4.2.2.5 Expressing Uncertainty

Expressing uncertainty was moderately used at 11.7% (7 instances). This often reflected genuine confusion when dealing with the male characters' complex or aggressive communication. This function is most clearly realized through performative hedges, a feature Lakoff (1975) associated with either a lack of confidence or a cooperative strategy. Table 4.21 provides a breakdown of the specific devices used.

Table 4.21

Frequency of Hedging Devices Used for Expressing Uncertainty by Female Characters

Hedging Devices	N°	%
I'm not sure	3	5
I don't know	2	3.3
I mean	1	1.7
I guess	1	1.7
SUBTOTAL	7	11.7
TOTAL	60	100

Table 4.21 shows that this function is dominated by the performative hedge "*I'm not sure*" (5%), a direct and explicit marker of uncertainty. This is followed by "*I don't know*" (3.3%). The reliance on this narrow set of explicit performative phrases indicates that when female characters express uncertainty, they tend to do so directly, often in response to confusing or overwhelming information from their conversational partners, as in:

(42)

Erica (F) ..sometimes you say two things at once and *I'm not sure*
which one I'm supposed to be aiming at.

In utterance (42), the performative hedge "*I'm not sure*" is a direct report of Erica's internal cognitive state. Instead of blaming Mark ("You're not making sense"), she takes ownership of her lack of understanding. This is a non-confrontational strategy, consistent with Lakoff's (1975) descriptions. It politely signals a breakdown in communication and requests clarification without assigning blame to the speaker.

4.2.2.6 Solidarity/Inclusiveness

Used in 6.7% of cases (4 instances), the function of *solidarity/inclusiveness* is a core positive politeness strategy designed to attend to the hearer's desire to be included and approved of, a concept central to the work of Brown and Levinson (1987). This relational aspect of language, where linguistic choices are made to foster rapport, was also extensively analyzed by Holmes (1995). In the film's dialogue, this function will be presented through modal hedges and inclusive pronouns. Table 4.22 illustrates the distribution of the specific linguistic tools used to achieve this function.

Table 4.22

Frequency of Hedging Devices Used for Solidarity/Inclusiveness by Female Characters

Hedging device	N°	%
We	2	3.3
must	1	1.7
Maybe	1	1.7
SUBTOTAL	4	6.7
TOTAL	60	100

As Table 4.22 illustrates, this function is performed by a small but specific group of linguistic devices, totaling 4 instances (accounting for 6.7%). The most prominent tool is the inclusive pronoun "*We*", which accounts for half of the instances (2 times, 3.3%), indicating a direct strategy to build consensus. The other devices, including the modal hedge "*must*" (1.7%) and the adverb "*Maybe*" (1.7%), each appear once. To demonstrates an effective combination of the adverb "*Maybe*" as in:

(43)

Christy (F) *Maybe* we can all go out and grab a drink later.

In utterance (43), the modal hedge "*Maybe*" makes the invitation a low-pressure suggestion. The key element is "we all," an inclusive pronoun that actively constructs a new, temporary social group including everyone present. This phrasing creates a friendly, open atmosphere and signals a desire to form a social connection, rather than just a simple exchange.

4.2.2.7 Strategic Vagueness

Used sparingly at 3.3% (2 instances), strategic vagueness involves being deliberately imprecise to avoid a difficult topic. This function, central to Hyland's (1998) framework of hedging as a strategic choice. Within the context of gendered communication, Holmes (1995) suggests that such indirect strategies are often employed to achieve relational goals and maintain social harmony. The minimal use of this function by female characters in the film is therefore significant, indicating they are rarely depicted in roles that require strategic evasion. Table 4.23 details the specific devices employed.

Table 4.23

Frequency of Hedging Devices Used for Strategic Vagueness by Female Characters

Hedging Device	N°	%
I don't know	1	1.7
As if	1	1.7
SUBTOTAL	2	3.3
TOTAL	60	100

As Table 4.23 illustrates, this function is realized through two distinct and unrelated hedges, each used only once. The performative hedge "*I don't know*" is used to dismiss a topic sarcastically, while the subjunctive phrase "*as if*" is used to

deliver a sharp critique. The rarity and diversity of these tools suggest that strategic vagueness is not a core component of the female characters' communicative toolkit, but rather a highly specialized strategy used in unique confrontational contexts.

(44)

K.C (F) *I don't know*, but I'm really hoping it's cats that look like
Hitler..

In utterance (44), the performative hedge "*I don't know*" is technically true but is immediately followed by sarcasm. This combination signals that her "I don't know" is not an invitation for more information but a dismissal of the topic. The vagueness is strategic because it allows her to avoid engaging with a topic she finds irritating. It shuts down the line of inquiry in a humorous but definitive way.

4.2.2.8 Infrequent and Absent Functions

The three least common functions highlight what is *not* prioritized in the female characters' discourse: strategic maneuvering and direct persuasion.

Persuasion strategy (3.3%, 2 instances) and *tentativeness/open-mindedness*

(1.7%, 1 instance) are minimally present. Their scarcity suggests that the women in the film are rarely depicted in roles where they are persuading others towards a strategic goal or showing hesitation.

A particularly interesting finding is the complete absence of *diplomatic*

avoidance (0%, 0 instances). In normal conversation, the total lack of this function would be unusual, as avoiding sensitive topics is a common social skill. However, within the context of the film, this absence is significant. The female characters, especially Erica and the lawyers, are often cast in roles that demand directness—they either confront Mark about his behavior or depose him with direct questions. Their narrative purpose is to be catalysts for truth or confrontation, not to engage in the strategic evasion that characterizes much of Mark's own communication. Therefore, the absence of this function underscores their role as direct conversational counterparts rather than strategic players.

4.2.3 Similarities and Differences in the Functions of Hedging Devices Used by Male and Female Characters

The quantitative analysis in section 4.1 has already shown that male and female characters in *'The Social Network'* choose different hedging tools. However, it is the functional analysis in section 4.2 that truly illuminates the most profound difference: they not only use different words, but they use them to execute two almost opposing sets of communicative strategies. The male toolkit is proactive and controlling, while the female toolkit is reactive and navigational. Table 4.24 provides the statistical evidence for this claim, illustrating the starkly different priorities in male and female communicative functions.

Table 4.24

Distribution of Functions of Hedging Devices Used by Male and Female Characters

	N	Modality markers	o	o	N	o	Male	Female	%	N	%
1 Expressing Uncertainty	13	4.6	7	11.7							
2 Politeness/Softening	48	16.9	11	18.3							
3 Mitigating Face-Threatening Acts	39	13.7	21	35							
4 Tentativeness/Open-mindedness	4	1.4	1	1.7							
5 Solidarity/Inclusiveness	10	3.5	4	6.7							
6 Strategic Vagueness	16	5.6	2	3.3							
7 Persuasion Strategy	77	27.1	2	3.3							
8 Hedging Knowledge/Evidentiality	54	19.4	4	6.7							
9 Diplomatic Avoidance	12	4.2	0	0							
10 Creating Space for Response	11	3.9	8	13.3							
Total	284	100	60	100							

4.2.3.1 Similarities in the Functions of Hedging Devices Used by Male and Female Characters

As indicated in Table 4.24, despite the divergent overall strategies, some fundamental interactive functions are shared by both genders. For instance, both male and female characters employ hedges for *Politeness/Softening* with a remarkably similar frequency; this function accounts for 16.9% of hedges used by men and 18.3% by women. Examples of this include the lawyer Sy (M) and Marilyn (F) using *can* in questions like "Can we do that?" and "Can we establish a timeline?" to make requests professionally.

Similarly, both genders use hedges for *mitigating face-threatening acts*. However, it is here that the similarity proves to be superficial. While men utilize this function in 13.7% of instances (e.g., when Mark uses *I think* to soften an insult), it is the single most dominant function for female characters, accounting for a substantial 35% of their total usage (e.g., when Erica uses *sometimes* to soften a criticism). Although they perform the same function, the vast difference in prioritization and frequency reveals significant underlying strategic differences, as will be clarified in the next section.

4.2.3.2 Differences in the Functions of Hedging Devices Used by Male and Female Characters

Table 4.24 shows some differences in the functions of hedging devices used by male and female characters, which are the core of this analysis, and it is starkly reflected in the statistical data. The data reveals two opposing communicative priorities: the most used function by men is *persuasion strategy*, accounting for a dominant 27.1% of their usage, while this same function is almost negligible for women at only 3.3%. Conversely, the top function for women is *mitigating face-threatening acts* at a substantial 35%, a strategy that, while present, is a much lower priority for men at 13.7%. This statistical gap immediately highlights a fundamental difference between a male toolkit aimed at imposing a viewpoint and a female toolkit designed to manage confrontational interactions.

This opposition is further illustrated by how the two genders use similar tools for different purposes. A prime example is the tag question. Male characters exclusively use *Right?* not to ask, but as a rhetorical tool to compel agreement, as when Sean declares: "This is our time, right?". Meanwhile, the only instance used by a female character is *Okay?*, a tool to seek understanding from a weaker position, as when Erica says: "I was honestly just asking. Okay?". The same grammatical structure, yet one is used to impose, the other to appeal.

Similarly, while men weaponize *I know* to assert intellectual dominance, women use *I think* to offer professional advice non-imposingly. Even when using the same word, the purpose differs. Men use *if* to construct legal and business scenarios to strengthen their arguments; women use *as if* to deliver a sarcastic critique.

Ultimately, this functional difference does not reflect an inherent nature of "male language" or "female language." Instead, it accurately reflects the power dynamics portrayed in the film. The male characters, as the architects and controllers of the events, use hedging as a tool to assert that power. The female characters, often in a reactive position, use hedging as an intelligent tool to navigate and survive within a discourse dominated by others.

CHAPTER 5. CONCLUSION

This final chapter synthesizes the entire research project. It begins by summarizing the major findings derived from the analysis in Chapter 4. Following this, the study's significant contributions to the field of sociolinguistics are outlined. The chapter then presents the theoretical and practical implications of the findings. Finally, it acknowledges the limitations of the research and provides concrete suggestions for future studies.

5.1 An Overview of the Study

This study was conducted to investigate the similarities and differences in the use of hedging devices, especially the types and functions, from a gender perspective within the competitive communicative environment of the film "*The Social Network*." To achieve this goal, the research addressed four research questions:

1. What types of hedging devices are used by male and female characters in the film '*The Social Network*' (2010)?
2. What are the gender similarities and differences in the use of hedging devices by male and female characters in the film '*The Social Network*' (2010)?
3. What pragmatic functions do hedging devices used by male and female characters perform in the conversations in the film '*The Social Network*' (2010)?
4. What are the similarities and differences in the pragmatic functions of hedging devices used by male and female characters in the conversations in the film '*The Social Network*' (2010)?

The present study applied a mixed-methods research design, combining both quantitative and qualitative analysis. The classification of these devices was based on the theoretical framework of Yu (2009), while the analysis of their functions was guided by a synthesized model drawing from the works of key pragmatists.

5.2 Summary of Main Findings

This study analyzed hedging devices in the film '*The Social Network*' (2010) through the interplay of a gender perspective within a competitive communicative environment. A total of 344 hedging instances (comprising 284 instances used by male characters and 60 instances used by female characters) were identified, annotated, and examined. These instances were analyzed based on five (5) main types of hedging devices according to Yu's (2009) model and ten (10) pragmatic functions based on a synthesized theoretical model (drawing from Lakoff (1975), Brown and Levinson (1987), Holmes (1995), and Hyland (1998)).

The initial findings respond to the first research question, "What types of hedging devices are used by male and female characters in the film '*The Social Network*' (2010)?", the analysis reveals distinct linguistic repertoires corresponding to gender. Male characters demonstrate a pronounced reliance on *modal hedges*, such as "*can*" and "*should*", which are conventional grammatical forms. In contrast,

female characters utilize a more diversified repertoire, exhibiting a notable preference for *performative hedges* (e.g., “*I think*”) and pragmatic markers (e.g., “*just*”).

With respect to the second research question, “What are the gender similarities and differences in the use of hedging devices by male and female characters in the film ‘*The Social Network*’ (2010)?”, examining the similarities and differences in usage, a principal distinction emerges in the preferred categories. Male characters display a consistent preference for modal hedges, whereas their utilization of performative hedges is notably infrequent. Conversely, female characters employ a more varied array of performative and pragmatic markers. The study indicates negligible overlap in the types of devices deployed, highlighting a clear “division of labor” in their strategic linguistic choices.

The analysis subsequently addresses the third research question, “What pragmatic functions do hedging devices used by male and female characters perform in the conversations in the film ‘*The Social Network*’ (2010)?”, pertaining to the pragmatic functions of hedging. It is demonstrated that hedging serves fundamentally divergent purposes for each gender. For male characters, the primary communicative function is identified as *persuasion strategy*; hedges are utilized to enhance the palatability of arguments and achieve instrumental objectives. For female characters, the strategy is overwhelmingly one of relational management and conflict avoidance. Their most significant function is *mitigating face-threatening acts*, employed to soften interpersonally difficult messages and maintain social harmony.

Finally, in response to the fourth research question (“What are the similarities and differences in the pragmatic functions of hedging devices used by male and female characters in the conversations in the film ‘*The Social Network*’ (2010)?”), concerning functional similarities and differences, the functional divergence is profound, with minimal convergence. Male characters deploy a proactive, instrumental strategy - which can be characterized as ‘offensive’ - using hedges to advance their argumentative positions and achieve goals. In stark contrast, female characters adopt a reactive, ‘defensive’ strategy. Their hedging is oriented towards managing social dynamics. This core dichotomy confirms that hedging is strategically deployed by male characters for instrumental gain, whereas for female characters, it functions as a tool for relational management.

In summary, the study reveals a clear “division of labor” in the use of hedging. Male characters employ a proactive, instrumental strategy, using a robust toolkit of conventional modal verbs primarily for persuasion and goal achievement. Their hedging is offensive in the strategic sense - it aims to advance their position. Female characters, on the other hand, adopt a reactive, relational strategy. Their hedging is defensive, using a varied set of performative and pragmatic markers to soften blows, avoid conflict, and manage the social dynamics of conversation. This core difference highlights that hedging in the film is not a simple marker of gender but a strategic tool deployed for fundamentally different communicative purposes.

Ultimately, the findings presented successfully answer the research questions posed at the beginning of this study. The analysis has quantitatively identified the distinct types and frequencies of hedging devices favoured by male and female characters, respectively. Furthermore, by analyzing the communicative functions

these hedges serve, the study has demonstrated that male characters primarily use hedging for persuasion, while female characters use it to mitigate interpersonal conflict. These results confirm that gender, as depicted in the film, plays a significant role in the strategic application of hedging, reflecting different conversational goals and strategies.

5.3 Implications of the Study

The findings of this study offer significant theoretical and practical implications.

Theoretical Implications: This research contributes a functional and context-dependent model for analyzing hedging. It encourages researchers to shift from the question "who hedges more?" to the question "what strategic purpose does hedging serve in this specific interaction?".

Practical Implications:

-For Communication and Negotiation: This study demonstrates that hedging is a critical tool in strategic communication, particularly in business and legal settings. Understanding how hedges can be used to assert dominance, create ambiguity, or de-escalate conflict can provide professionals with a more sophisticated understanding of language as a tool for negotiation and persuasion.

-For Education: For learners of English, particularly in professional contexts, this research serves as a valuable case study. It highlights that the function of linguistic devices is not fixed but fluid. It encourages an awareness of language that goes beyond dictionary definitions to include strategic and pragmatic competence, helping students and teachers recognize how seemingly "polite" or "uncertain" words can be used for powerful rhetorical effects.

5.4 Limitations of the Study

While this study has endeavored to conduct a thorough analysis, its findings should be considered in light of several methodological limitations:

Data Source: The primary limitation is that the data is drawn from a single, fictional screenplay. While meticulously crafted, scripted dialogue reflects the artistic choices of the screenwriter and may not perfectly mirror the patterns of spontaneous, natural conversation. The findings, therefore, are representative of gendered communication as depicted in this specific cultural artifact, not necessarily of real-world interactions.

Sample Imbalance: The film's narrative is heavily dominated by male characters, resulting in a significantly smaller dataset for female speech. Consequently, while the conclusions about male hedging strategies are robustly supported by the data, the findings regarding female speech are less generalizable and should be interpreted with caution due to the limited sample size.

Linguistic Focus: As defined in the scope of the study, this research focuses exclusively on linguistic hedging devices. It does not extend to paralinguistic factors (such as tone of voice, gestures, or facial expressions) which can also function to mitigate or hedge an utterance. This limitation was established due to the high complexity and ongoing scholarly debate surrounding the systematic analysis of such non-verbal cues from a film script alone.

5.5 Suggestions for Further Research

Building upon the findings and acknowledging the limitations of this study, several promising avenues for future research are proposed to develop a more comprehensive understanding of gender and hedging.

First, future research should expand the scope of analysis to include natural, spontaneous conversation. The current study is based on a fictional screenplay, which may not fully represent real-world speech patterns. A comparative study using a corpus of unscripted, real-life interactions (such as recorded meetings, interviews, or casual conversations) would be invaluable. This would allow researchers to validate whether the gendered communicative strategies observed in *'The Social Network'*, the proactive male toolkit versus the reactive female toolkit are, indeed reflective of broader sociolinguistic realities or are specific to their cinematic depiction.

Second, subsequent studies should aim to address the significant sample imbalance present in this film's dataset. To achieve a more robust and generalizable understanding of female hedging strategies, researchers could analyze films or media with female protagonists or narratives that offer more equitable screen time and dialogue between genders. Furthermore, exploring different genres, such as romantic comedies or dramas centered on female relationships, could reveal different functional priorities and provide a much-needed counterbalance to the male-dominated context of this study.

Third, it is recommended that further investigation adopts a multimodal approach that incorporates paralinguistic features. This study was deliberately limited to linguistic devices due to the constraints of script-based analysis. However, a future study analyzing the audio-visual film itself could examine the interplay between verbal hedges and non-verbal cues like intonation, facial expressions, and gestures. Such an analysis would provide a more holistic and nuanced picture of how speakers perform and audiences perceive hedging, revealing how paralinguistic elements can reinforce, contradict, or modify the function of a spoken utterance.

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học Quốc gia Hà Nội

APPENDIX

08:45

Mark (M): You don't have to study. You go to B.U. I'm not saying it's not a real school, I'm just saying you're not likely to fail out and have to move back home to your parents' house, which you've never had to do.

Erica (F): "I *think* we *should just* be friends." 01:48:50

Eduardo (M): Wait, what is this?

Lawyer (M): *Well*, as you know we had some new investors-- Eduardo (M): What is this?

Lawyer (M): If you'll let me--

00:14:12

Mark (M): (V.O.) Lowell has some security. They require a username/password combo and I'm going to go ahead and say they don't have access to main FAS user database, so they have no way of detecting an intrusion.

Mark (M): (V.O.) Adams has no security but limits the number of results to twenty a page. All I need to do is break out the same script I used on Lowell and we're set. Mark (M): (V.O.) Quincy has no online facebook, what a sham. Nothing I can do about that.

00:04:44

Mark (M): You *can* see why it's so important to get in. Erica (F): Okay, well, which is the easiest to get into? Mark (M): Why would you ask me that?

01:54:55

Mark (M): Yes, all behind a Pix Firewall Emulator. But here's the beauty. Eduardo (M): You know I didn't understand anything you just said, *right*? Mark (M): I do know that.

01:25:48

Amy (F): What was your latest preneur?

Sean (M): *Well*...I founded an internet company that let folks download and share music for free.

Amy (F): Kind of like Napster?

Sean (M): Exactly like Napster.

00:14:10

Mark (M): (V.O.) Lowell has *some* security. They require a username/password combo and I'm going to go ahead and say they don't have access to main FAS user database, so they have no way of detecting an intrusion.

01:27:14

Amy (F): You're a zillionaire.

Sean (M): *Not technically*.

Amy (F): What are you?

Sean (M): Broke. There's not a lot of money in free music. Even less when you're being sued by everyone who's ever been to the Grammys. 00:23:40

Sy (M): Why don't we stretch our legs for a minute, can we do that? It's been almost three hours and frankly you did spend an awful lot of time embarrassing Mr. Zuckerberg with the girl's testimony from the bar.

Mark (M): I'm not embarrassed, she just made a lot of that up. Gretchen (F): She was under oath.

Mark (M): Then *I guess* that would be the first time somebody's lied under oath. 01:32:57

Tyler (M): I'm sorry President Summers, what you just said makes no sense to me at all.

Summers (M): I'm devastated by that.

Cameron (M): What my brother means is that if Mark Zuckerberg walked into our dorm room and stole our computer that would be a university issue, right? 00:39:50

Mark (M): People came to Facemash in a stampede, right? Eduardo (M): Yeah.

Mark (M): It wasn't because they saw pictures of hot girls. You can go anywhere on the internet and see pictures of hot girls.

00:45:00

Gage (M): (reading) From Mark Zuckerberg to Tyler Winklevoss. November 30, 2003. "I read over all the stuff you sent me re Harvard Connection and *it seems* like it shouldn't take too long to implement, so we can talk about it after I get all the basic functionality up tomorrow night."

00:52:32

Marylin (F): "*Can* we establish a timeline?"

01:39:03

Eduardo (M): He's not a god.

Mark (M): What is he?

Eduardo (M): 25 minutes late.

Christy (F): *I think* Wardo's jealous. 00:03:00

Mark (M): Or I can get into a final club.

Erica (F): *You know*, from a woman's perspective, sometimes not singing in a Capella group is a good thing?

Mark (M): This is serious.

00:04:44

Mark (M): You can see why it's so important to get in. Erica (F): Okay, *well*, which is the easiest to get into? Mark (M): Why would you ask me that?

01:29:13

Sean (M): I went to check my e-mail and there's a site open on your computer. Amy (F): After you passed out last night I went on the Facebook for *a little bit*. Sean (M): What's that?

00:05:33

Mark (M): You didn't ask me which one was the best one, you asked me which one was the easiest one.

Erica (F): I was honestly just asking. Okay? I was just asking to ask. Mark, I'm not speaking in code.

Mark (M): Erica--

00:06:50

Erica (F): Although just because something's trite it doesn't make it any less— Mark (M): I want to try to be straight forward with you and tell you that *I think* you might want to be a little more supportive. If I get in I'll be taking you...to the events, and the gatherings...and you'll be meeting a lot of people you wouldn't normally get to meet.

Erica (F): You would do that for me?

00:21:05

Eduardo (M): This is an awful lot of traffic. Think maybe we should shut it down before we get into trouble.

Mark (M): (ignores him)

00:39:15

Mark (M): You got punched by the Phoenix.

Eduardo (M): It was, you know...it was *probably* just a diversity thing. It was just a diversity thing.

Mark (M): (pause)

00:45:00

Gage (M): (reading) From Mark Zuckerberg to Tyler Winklevoss. November 30, 2003. "I read over all the stuff you sent me re Harvard Connection and *it seems* like it shouldn't take too long to implement, so we can talk about it after I get all the basic functionality up tomorrow night."

00:05:33

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Erica (F): You would do that for me?

01:07:34

Eduardo (M): Very nice to meet you.

Christy (F): Facebook me when you get home. Maybe we can all go out and grab a drink later.

Eduardo (M): Certainly. Absolutely I will do that. 00:08:00

Erica (F): Yes.

Mark (M): Okay, then wait. *I apologize*, okay? Erica (F): I have to go study.

00:08:45

Mark (M): Because you go to B.U.!

Erica (F): *I think* we should just be friends. Mark (M): I don't want friends.

00:06:18

"I'm saying I need to do *something* substantial in order to get the attention of the clubs."

00:06:18

Erica (F): I didn't mean to be cryptic.

Mark (M): I'm saying I need to do something substantial in order to get the attention of the clubs.

Erica (F): Why?

00:18:00

Eduardo (M): Who are you gonna send it to?

Mark (M): Just *a couple of* people. The question is, who are they gonna send it to? 00:03:34

Mark (M): To row crew? No. Are you, like--whatever--delusional? Erica (F): Maybe, but sometimes you say two things at once and *I'm not sure* which one I'm supposed to be aiming at.

Mark (M): But you've seen guys who row crew, right? 00:26:45

Divya (M): What were we doing that none of us heard about this? Cameron (M): *I don't know*, a three hour low-rate technical row before breakfast, a full course load, studying, another three hours in the tank and then studying. I don't know how we missed it.

Tyler (M): (reading) 22,000 page requests.

00:23:03

Gretchen (F): So you were called in front of the Ad Board. Mark (M): That's not what happened. No, back, *I mean*--That's--back at the bar with Erica Albright. She said all that?

Sy (M): Mark, I wouldn't—

01:03:00

Gage (M): Did you know that his father was wealthy. Mark (M): *I'm not sure* why you're asking me that. Gage (M): It's not important that you be sure why I'm asking you. 00:37:05

Gretchen (F): When did you approach Mr. Saverin with the idea for TheFacebook? Mark (M): I *wouldn't* say I approached him. Gretchen (F): Sy?

00:35:10

Tyler (M): The difference between what we're talking about and MySpace or Friendster or any of those other social networking site—

Mark (M): --is exclusivity. *Right?*

Divya (M): Right.

00:42:07

Mark (M): It *probably* was a diversity thing but so what? Gretchen (F): (V.O.) Why do you think he said that? Sy (M): (V.O.) Gretchen, excuse me for interrupting but whose discovery is this? 00:16:15

Mark (M): We're ranking girls.

Eduardo (M): You *think* this is such a good idea? Mark (M): I need the algorithm.

00:08:14

Mark (M): I'm sorry, I mean it.

Erica (F): *I appreciate that* but I have to study. Mark (M): You don't have to study. You don't have to study. Let's just talk. 00:05:33

Mark (M): You didn't ask me which one was the best one, you asked me which one was the easiest one.

Erica (F): I was honestly just asking. Okay? I was *just* asking to ask. Mark, I'm not speaking in code.

Mark (M): Erica--

00:04:02

Mark (M): Okay.

Erica (F): *Should* we get something to eat? Mark (M): Would you like to talk about something else? 01:07:34

Eduardo (M): Very nice to meet you.

Christy (F): Facebook me when you get home. *Maybe* we can all go out and grab a drink later.

Eduardo (M): Certainly. Absolutely I will do that.

00:00:06

Mark (M): (V.O.) Did you know there are more people with genius IQ's living in China than there are people of any kind living in the United States?

Erica (F): (V.O.) That *can't possibly* be true. Mark (M): (V.O.) It is.

00:57:00

Female Friend (F): What is it?

K.C. (F): *I don't know*, but I'm really hoping it's cats that look like Hitler 'cause I can never get enough of that.

K.C. (F): It's not.

CỘNG HÒA XÃ HỘI CHỦ NGHĨA VIỆT NAM

Độc lập – Tự do – Hạnh phúc

Gia Lai, ngày 29 tháng 10 năm 2025

BẢN GIẢI TRÌNH

ĐÃ CHỈNH SỬA, HOÀN THIỆN ĐỀ ÁN/LUẬN VĂN THẠC SĨ

Kính gửi: Hội đồng đánh giá đề án/luận văn thạc sĩ ngành Ngôn ngữ Anh

Họ và tên học viên: HỒ THÁI BẢO QUỲNH; Mã số học viên: 8262751005 Ngày tháng năm sinh: 08/10/2001;

Ngành: Ngôn ngữ Anh; Mã ngành: 8220201 Khóa: 26 ; Điện thoại: 0967782429 Tên đề án/luận văn (ghi đúng tên đề án/luận văn thạc sĩ sau khi Hội đồng đánh giá thông qua Quyết nghị): Hedging Devices in the film “The Social Network” (2010): Similarities and Differences from a Gender Perspective

Người hướng dẫn: TS. Trương Văn Định-(cơ quan công tác) Trường Đại học Quy Nhơn Ngày bảo vệ đề án/luận văn: 19/10/2025- tại: Trường Đại học Quy Nhơn Theo yêu cầu của Hội đồng đánh giá đề án/luận văn thạc sĩ, tôi đã chỉnh sửa, hoàn thiện các nội dung như sau:

Nội dung chỉnh sửa

TT Trước khi chỉnh sửa Ghi Sau khi chỉnh sửa

chú

Trang, Trang,

Mục, yêu cầu Mục, yêu cầu

dòng dòng

1 5 Abbreviations: đã điều chỉnh 5 Abbreviations: Điều chỉnh

đúng theo thứ tự Bảng chữ theo đúng thứ tự Bảng chữ cái cái

2 19 Tiêu đề 2.1: An Overview of 19 Tiêu đề mục 2.1: An

Overview of Hedge Hedges

3 23 Tiêu đề 2.1.2: Classification of 23 Tiêu đề mục 2.1.2:

Classification of Hedge Hedges

4 31 Tiêu đề mục 2.2: Importance 31 Tiêu đề mục 2.2:

Importance of Hedge in of Hedges in Conversation Conversation

5 44 present study's validity 44

Lỗi đánh máy: resent

study's validity

6 63 as in 63 Lỗi đánh máy: ass in

7 50 Tiêu đề mục 4.1: Hedging 50 Tiêu đề mục 4.1: Types of

Hedging Devices Used by Devices Used by Male and Male and Female Female Characters Characters in 'The Social

Network' (2010)

8 50 Tiêu đề mục 4.1.1: Hedging 50 Tiêu đề mục 4.1.1: Types

of Hedging Devices Used Devices Used by Male by Male Characters Characters

9 63 Tiêu đề mục 4.1.2: Hedging 63 Tiêu đề mục 4.1.2: Types

of Hedging Devices Used Devices Used by Female by Female Characters in Characters 'The Social Network'

(2010)

10 72 Tiêu đề mục 4.1.3: Similarities 72 Tiêu đề mục 4.1.3:

Similarities and and Differences in the Use of Differences in the Use of Hedging Devices by Male and Hedging Devices by Male Female Characters and Female Characters in

the film 'The Social

Network' (2010)

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of Hedging Devices Used Hedging Devices Used by by Male and Female Male and Female Characters Characters in the film 'The

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12 102 Tiêu đề mục 4.2.3: Similarities 102 Tiêu đề mục 4.2.3:

Similarities and and Differences in the Differences in the Functions of Hedging Devices Functions of Hedging Used by Male and Female Devices Used by Male and Characters Female Characters in the

Film 'The Social Network'

(2010)

13 106 Nội dung mục 5.2 (Summary 106 Nội dung mục 5.2

(Summary of Main of Main Findings): đã bổ sung Findings): thêm phần Discussion cho phù hợp với 4 Discussion cho phù hợp Research Questions của Đề án.

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Sắp xếp lại thứ tự mục

Politeness/Softening

4.2.2.3: Creating Space for
Response

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4.2.2.5: Solidarity/
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Sắp xếp lại thứ tự mục

Solidarity/ Inclusiveness

4.2.2.6: Hedging

Knowledge/Evidentiality

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Học viên Người hướng dẫn Thành viên Hội đồng

(Ghi rõ chức trách trong HĐ)

Hồ Thái Bảo Quỳnh TS. Trương Văn Định